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ContentsDedication

Preface

Introduction: Freedom

Sovereignty

Unpredictability

Mobility

Factuality

Solidarity

Conclusion: Government

Appendix

Acknowledgments

Notes

Index

About the Author

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For those who wish to be free

Preface“What do you think?” asked Mariia, smiling, in her bright dress, as I ducked under the doorframe of her orderly little hut and stepped back into the sunshine and rubble. “Everything as it should be?” It was. Her rugs and blankets, laid out in nice rectilinear patterns, recalled Ukrainian futurist art. The cords leading to her generator were tidily arranged, and water bottles were near at hand. A thick book lay open on her bed.

Outside her metal domicile, a temporary dwelling provided by an international organization, woolen sweaters were drying on a line. A pretty wooden drawer, lined in felt, rested on a bench, like an open Pandora’s box. When I complimented her on it, Mariia offered the drawer to me as a gift. It was a lonely relic of her house, just in front of us, a ruin after bombs and shells. She looked up nervously at a passing plane. “Everything happened,” she sighed, “and none of it was necessary.”

Like every house in the village, Mariia’s was destroyed during the Russian invasion of Ukraine. Posad Pokrovs’ke, in the far south of the country, was at the edge of the Russian advance. It rests among fields of sunflowers in this fertile region. The Ukrainian army pushed the Russians out of artillery range in late 2022, making it safe to return, or to visit, as I am doing now, in September 2023.

Taking a seat on the bench and listening to Mariia, I think about freedom. The village, one would say, has been liberated. Are its people free?

To be sure, something terrible has been removed from Mariia’s life: the daily threat of violent death, an occupation by torturers and murderers. But is that, even that, liberation?

Mariia is eighty-five years old and living alone. Now that she has her neat little residence, she is certainly freer than when she was homeless. That is because family and volunteers came to help. And because a government has acted, one to which she feels connected by her vote. Mariia does not complain of her own fate. She cries when she speaks of the difficult challenges faced by her president.

The Ukrainian word de-occupation, which she and I are using in conversation, is more precise than the conventional liberation. It invites us to consider what, beyond the removal of oppression, we might need for liberty. It takes work, after all, to get one older woman into a position where she can greet guests and perform the normal interactions of a dignified person. I have trouble imagining Mariia being truly free without a proper house with a chair and without a clear path to the road for her walker.

Freedom is not just an absence of evil but a presence of good.

—

Southern Ukraine is steppe; northern Ukraine is forest. Visiting a de-occupied town in the north of the country, I had similar thoughts about freedom. Having dropped off my children at friendly schools in New Haven, Connecticut, I made the journey to an abandoned school building in Yahidne, which Russian occupiers had transformed into a small concentration camp. For most of the time that the village was occupied, the Russians had packed 350 civilians, its entire population, into the school basement, an area of less than two hundred square meters. Seventy of the villagers were children, the youngest an infant.

Yahidne was de-occupied in April 2022, and I visited that September. On the ground floor, Russian soldiers had destroyed the furniture. On the walls, they left behind dehumanizing graffiti about Ukrainians. There was no electricity. By the light of my phone, I made my way down to the cellar, and examined the children’s drawings on its walls. I could read what they had written (“No to war”); my children later helped me identify the characters (such as an Impostor from the game Among Us).

By a doorframe were two lists, written in chalk, of the names of the perished: on one side, those executed by the

Russians (of whom, best as I could tell, there were seventeen); on the other, those who died from exhaustion or illness (of whom, best as I could tell, there were ten).

By the time I arrived in Yahidne, the survivors were no longer in the cellar. Were they free?

A liberation suggests a woe that has dissipated. But the adults need support, the children a new school. It is so very important that the town is no longer occupied. But it would be wrong to end the story of Yahidne when the survivors emerged from underground, just as it would be wrong to end the story of Posad Pokrovs'ke when the bombing stopped.

The gentleman entrusted with the key to the Yahidne school asked for help to build a playground. It might seem like a strange desire, amid a war of destruction. Russians kill children with missiles, and kidnap them for assimilation. But the absence of these crimes is not enough; de-occupation is not enough. Children need places to play, run, and swim, to practice being themselves. A child cannot create a park or a swimming pool. The joy of youth is to discover such things in the world. It takes collective work to build structures of freedom, for the young as for the old.

—

I came to Ukraine during the war while writing this book about freedom. Here its subject is palpable, all around. A month after Russia invaded Ukraine, I spoke with some Ukrainian lawmakers: "We chose freedom when we did not run." "We are fighting for freedom." "Freedom itself is the choice."

It was not just the politicians. Talking in wartime Ukraine to soldiers, to widows and farmers, to activists and journalists, I heard the word freedom over and over. It was interesting how they used it. With much of their country under genocidal occupation, Ukrainians would seem to have good reason to speak of freedom as a liberation from, as an absence of evil. No one did.

When asked what they meant by freedom, not a single person with whom I spoke specified freedom from the Russians. One Ukrainian told me, "When we say freedom, we do not mean 'freedom from something.' " Another defined victory as being "for something, not against something." The occupiers had gotten in the way of a sense that the world was opening up, that the next generation would have a better life, that decisions made now would matter in years to come.

It was essential to remove repression, to gain what philosophers call "negative freedom." But de-occupation, the removal of harm, was just a necessary condition for freedom, not the thing itself. A soldier in a rehabilitation center told me that freedom was about everyone having a chance to fulfill their own purposes after the war. A veteran awaiting a prosthesis said that freedom would be a smile on his son's face. A young soldier on leave said that freedom was about the children he would like to have. Their commander in his hidden staff room, Valeriy Zaluzhnyi, told me that freedom meant a normal life with prospects.

Freedom was a future when some things were the same and others were better. It was life expanding and growing.

—

In this book, I aim to define freedom. The task begins with rescuing the word from overuse and abuse. I worry that, in my own country, the United States, we speak of freedom without considering what it is. Americans often have in mind the absence of something: occupation, oppression, or even government. An individual is free, we think, when the government is out of the way. Negative freedom is our common sense.

To be sure, it is tempting to think of liberty as us against the world, which the notion of negative freedom allows us to do. If the barriers are the only problem, then all must be right with us. That makes us feel good. We think that we would be free if not for a world outside that does us wrong. But is the removal of something in the world really enough to liberate us? Is it not as important, perhaps even more important, to add things?

If we want to be free, we will have to affirm, not just deny. Sometimes we will have to destroy, but more often we will need to create. Most often we will need to adapt both the world and ourselves, on the basis of what we know and value. We need structures, just the right ones, moral as well as political. Virtue is an inseparable part of

freedom.

“Stone Walls do not a Prison make / Nor Iron bars a Cage”—said the poet. Sometimes they do, and sometimes they don’t. Oppression is not just obstruction but the human intention behind it. In Ukraine’s Donetsk, an abandoned factory became an art lab; under Russian occupation, the same building became a torture facility. A school basement, as in Yahidne, can be a concentration camp.

Early Nazi concentration camps, for that matter, were in bars, hotels, and castles. The first permanent one, Dachau, was in an abandoned factory. Auschwitz had been a Polish military base meant to defend people from a German attack. Kozelsk, a Soviet POW camp where Polish officers were held before their execution, had been a monastery—the one where Fyodor Dostoevsky, in The Brothers Karamazov, set the dialogue with the famous question: If God is dead, is everything permitted?

No larger force makes us free, nor does the absence of such a larger force. Nature gives us a chance to be free, nothing less, nothing more. We are told that we are “born free”: untrue. We are born squalling, attached to an umbilical cord, covered in a woman’s blood. Whether we become free depends upon the actions of others, upon the structures that enable those actions, upon the values that enliven those structures—and only then upon a flicker of spontaneity and the courage of our own choices.

The structures that hinder or enable are physical and moral. It matters how we speak and think about freedom. Liberty begins with de-occupying our minds from the wrong ideas. And there are right and wrong ideas. In a world of relativism and cowardice, freedom is the absolute among absolutes, the value of values. This is not because freedom is the one good thing to which all others must bow. It is because freedom is the condition in which all the good things can flow within us and among us.

Nor is it because freedom is a vacuum left by a dead God or an empty world. Freedom is not an absence but a presence, a life in which we choose multiple commitments and realize combinations of them in the world. Virtues are real, as real as the starry heavens; when we are free, we learn them, exhibit them, bring them to life. Over time, our choices among virtues define us as people of will and individuality.

—

When we assume that freedom is negative, the absence of this or that, we presume that removing a barrier is all that we have to do to be free. To this way of thinking, freedom is the default condition of the universe, brought to us by some larger force when we clear the way. This is naïve.

Americans are told that we were given freedom by our Founding Fathers, our national character, or our capitalist economy. None of this is true. Freedom cannot be given. It is not an inheritance. We call America a “free country,” but no country is free. Noting a difference between the rhetoric of the oppressors and the oppressed, the dissident Eritrean poet Y. F. Mebrahtu reports that “they talk about the country, we talk about the people.” Only people can be free. If we believe something else makes us free, we never learn what we must do. The moment you believe that freedom is given, it is gone.

We Americans tend to think that freedom is a matter of things being cleared away, and that capitalism does that work for us. It is a trap to believe in this or any other external source of freedom. If we associate freedom with outside forces, and someone tells us that the outside world delivers a threat, we sacrifice liberty for safety. This makes sense to us, because in our hearts we were already unfree. We believe that we can trade freedom for security. This is a fatal mistake.

Freedom and security work together. The preamble of the Constitution instructs that “the blessings of liberty” are to be pursued alongside “the general welfare” and “the common defense.” We must have liberty and safety. For people to be free, they must feel secure, especially as children. They must have a chance to know one another and the world. Then, as they become free people, they decide what risks to take, and for what reasons.

When Russia invaded Ukraine, President Volodymyr Zelens’kyi did not tell his people that they needed to trade liberty for safety. He told them that he was staying in the country. After my visit to Yahidne, I spoke to him in his office in Kyiv, behind the sandbags. He called de-occupation a chance to restore both security and freedom. He said

that the “deprivation of freedom was insecurity,” and that “insecurity was the deprivation of freedom.”

—

Freedom is about knowing what we value and bringing it to life. So it depends on what we can do—and that, in turn, depends on others, people we know and people we don’t.

As I write this preface on a westbound night train from Kyiv, I know how long I have before I reach the Polish border. I have a bit of security in that knowledge, and a bit of freedom to work—thanks to the labor of other people. Someone else laid the rail lines and repairs them when they are shelled, someone else built the carriages and looks after them, someone else is driving the train. When the Ukrainian army de-occupies cities, it raises the flag and shares the photos. But Ukrainians tend to regard cities as liberated when rail service has been restored.

Russian propagandists claim that there is no right and no good, and so everything is permitted. The consequences of that view are all around me in de-occupied Ukraine, in the death pits I saw at Bucha, in ruined settlements such as Posad Pokrovs’ke, in concentration camps such as Yahidne. Russian soldiers in Ukraine speak of cities they destroy as “liberated.” And indeed: all barriers, from their perspective, have been removed. They can bulldoze the rubble and the corpses, as in Mariupol, build something else, sell it. In that negative sense of free, they are free to murder and steal.

The wheels and tracks beneath me are not making me free, but they are carrying me forward, creating conditions for my freedom that I could not create myself. I would be a less free person right now were there no train, or had Russia destroyed the Kyiv rail station. People in Ukraine were not freer when Russia destroyed public utilities and public schools.

We enable freedom not by rejecting government, but by affirming freedom as the guide to good government. Reasoning forward from the right definition of freedom, I believe, will get us to the right sort of government. And so this book begins with an introduction about freedom, and ends with a conclusion about government. The five chapters in between show the way from philosophy to policy.

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How does freedom figure in our lives? The connections between freedom as a principle and freedom as a practice are the five forms of freedom.

The forms create a world where people act on the basis of values. They are not rules or orders. They are the logical, moral, and political links between common action and the formation of free individuals. The forms resolve two apparent conundrums: a free person is an individual, but no one becomes an individual alone; freedom is felt in one lifetime, but it must be the work of generations.

The five forms are: sovereignty, or the learned capacity to make choices; unpredictability, the power to adapt physical regularities to personal purposes; mobility, the capacity to move through space and time following values; factuality, the grip on the world that allows us to change it; and solidarity, the recognition that freedom is for everyone.

The labor of freedom begins after the labor of a mother. A baby has the potential to evaluate the world and change it, and it develops the requisite capabilities with the support of and in the company of others. This is sovereignty.

Coming of age, a young human being learns to see the world as it is and to imagine how it might be. A sovereign person mixes chosen virtues with the world outside to make something new. Thus unpredictability is the second form of freedom.

Our bodies need places to go. We cannot as young people create for ourselves the conditions that will allow us to be sovereign and unpredictable. But once those conditions have been created, we rebel against the very institutions that made them possible and go our own way. And this mobility, the third form of freedom, is to be encouraged.

We are free to do only the things we know how to do, and free to go only to places where we can go. What we don’t know can hurt us, and what we do know empowers us. Freedom’s fourth form is factuality.

No individual achieves freedom alone. Practically and ethically, freedom for you means freedom for me. This recognition is solidarity, the final form of freedom.

The solution to the problem of freedom is not, as some on the Right think, to mock or abandon government. The solution is also not, as some on the Left think, to ignore or cast away the rhetoric of freedom.

Freedom justifies government. The forms of freedom show us how.

—

This book follows the logic of an argument and the logic of a life. The first three forms of freedom pertain to different phases of life: sovereignty to childhood; unpredictability to youth; mobility to young adulthood. Factuality and solidarity are the mature forms of freedom, enabling the others. Each form has a chapter.

In the introduction, I draw on my own life, beginning with the first time I remember thinking about freedom: during the summer of 1976, the American bicentennial year. I will try to show, on the basis of five decades of my own mistakes, how some misunderstandings of freedom arose, and how they might be corrected. The conclusion describes a good government, one that we might create together. There I imagine an America that has reached the year 2076, its tercentennial, as a land of the free.

The chapters are divided into vignettes. Some of them include memories that sprang to mind as I was trying to address a philosophical issue. The flashes of recollection enable some reflection. They allow me to apply a humble version of the Socratic method to my earlier self: questioning the sense of words and the habits of life, to awaken what is, in some sense, already known. The point is to elicit truths about this country and about freedom that were not evident to me in the moment—and that would not be evident to me now had I not passed through those earlier experiences.

This is a philosophical method (I hope) fitting for a historian, which is what I am. I rely on historical examples and know more about the past of some regions than others. This is a book about the United States, but I draw comparisons with western Europe, eastern Europe, the Soviet Union, and Nazi Germany.

I am in discussion here with philosophers ancient, modern, and contemporary. Sometimes I leave the references implicit; those who care will catch them. I do cite explicitly five thinkers: Frantz Fanon, Václav Havel, Leszek Kołakowski, Edith Stein, and Simone Weil. These figures are not American and are not well known in the United States; with minor exceptions, they neither resided in the country nor wrote about it. A prodding from another tradition (or a term from another language) can shake us free of misapprehensions. I adapt from each thinker a concept that advances the argument; I do not claim that they agree with one another (or with me) on every issue.

This book is conservative, in that it draws from tradition; but radical, in that it proposes something new. It is philosophy, but it cleaves to experience. A few phrases in this book are text messages that I wrote to myself in intermittent moments of consciousness in a hospital bed, during an illness that nearly took my life. Arguments were conceived while teaching a class inside an American maximum security prison. I wrote much of what follows during three journeys to wartime Ukraine.

The fundamental questions were posed by readers. My books Bloodlands and Black Earth, studies of mass killing, led to public discussions that moved me toward the ethical subject of this book. If I can describe the worst, can I not also prescribe the best? After I published the political pamphlet On Tyranny and a contemporary history called The Road to Unfreedom, I was asked what a better America would look like. This is my answer.

Defining freedom is a different sort of ambition from defending it. I interrogate my former self; I interrogate others; and others interrogate me. The method is part of the answer: there may be truth about freedom, but we will not get to it in isolation or by deduction. Freedom is positive; getting words around it, like living it, is an act of creation.

This book is meant to exemplify the virtues it commends. It is, I hope, reasonable, but also unpredictable. It is intended to be sober, but also experimental. It celebrates not who we are, but the freedom that could be ours.

The sun rises outside my window. The border approaches. I begin my reflection on a summer day.

T.S.

Kyiv-Dorohusk train

Wagon 10, Compartment 9

6:10 a.m., September 10, 2023

IntroductionFreedomJubileeIt is summer 1976, a sunny afternoon on an Ohio farm. Wisps of cloud flit across the sky; gravel presses underfoot. A boy of six, going on seven, stands in line next to a farmhouse to ring a bell: the me that I once was, full of futures.

A gravel lane winds upward from the country road. It bends as the hill crests, between a maple tree that extends across the first few rows of a cornfield and an old sycamore that shades the farmhouse. On the maple hangs a swing, slowly oscillating now from my leap to earth. Past the house, the lane continues to two round corncribs and an old wooden barn, then fades into a path sloping downward to a pond. On both sides of the lane are fields of fossils and arrowheads, as I think of them, covered now in rising stalks of corn.

I am on the farm with my mother's family, to celebrate summer birthdays and commemorate two hundred years of American independence. Each cousin, in line from the oldest to the youngest, is taking a turn at the bell. Its distinctive double ring resounds through my childhood: a nice high peal, followed by an awkward lower one, as the bell's clapper meets the lip an unintended second time. The bell has a flaw.

My turn comes. The bell weighs as much as I do, but it is well mounted, and I know how to move it. Hands clenched around the rope, eyes closed, I lean back to make a lever of my body. Gravity does my work. The bell rings out, unmistakable and imperfect. I open my eyes, still leaning back, and see only blue. I am thinking about freedom.

After every kid has rung the bell, we all tumble through a whitewashed screened-in porch, where a mastodon tusk hangs on the far wall. I pause there for a moment to find my sneakers, then tread into the kitchen, the last to join a circle formed for silent grace. I catch a glimpse of the basket of outgoing mail, mounted on the wall behind me. The Liberty Bell stamps cite the biblical injunction inscribed on the bell itself: in a jubilee year, "Proclaim liberty throughout all the land."

The Liberty Bell is cracked. The fissure was right there on the stamp. The bell in question was forged in 1752 for the Pennsylvania Statehouse in Philadelphia for a different jubilee, the half-century of the colony's Charter of Privileges. The flaw we see now appeared when it was rung on George Washington's birthday in 1846.

The next words of that biblical verse suggest a way to interpret the crack: "ye shall return every man unto his possession, and ye shall return every man unto his family" (Leviticus 25:10). In the nineteenth century, abolitionists read those words as a call to end American slavery. They took the bell at the Philadelphia statehouse as their symbol and gave it the name we know today. Later the Liberty Bell was used by the woman suffrage movement.

In 1976 the stamp codified a patriotic legend: that a Liberty Bell was rung as the Declaration of Independence was declaimed in Philadelphia in July 1776. Neither was the bell rung then, nor did it bear that name. The Liberty Bell was named in reference to those who gained no liberty. It was used to claim a better future, not to commemorate an ideal past.

The bicentennial was a tricky idea for a child. It called me to a world where freedom had been achieved two centuries before because something, a British Empire, had been removed. We, the Americans, were then supposed to be liberated eternally. As a bicentennial symbol, the Liberty Bell was stripped of its reference to women and Black people, suggesting a perfect achievement of freedom long ago complete.

It might at first seem logical that freedom is an absence and seem fair that the government should leave each of us equally alone. This intuition draws its plausibility from a history of exploitation. Traditionally, some people have regarded themselves as free because they exploit the labor of slaves and women. Those who believe themselves free because they dominate others define freedom negatively, as the absence of government, because only a government could emancipate the slaves or enfranchise the women. The conflation of a Liberty Bell with the American Revolution dodges the issue of what freedom is, and for whom that bell tolls.

As a boy of six going on seven, I had heard the phrase underground railroad and had wondered what it would be like to hide in the farmhouse cellar. But it would not have occurred to me to ask whether American independence meant freedom for everyone. Black kids my age would not have needed to ask, since the answer was out there, in life itself.

FlightsThe bell rings. Time for freedom. Time for dinner. Since my birthday is closest, I jump to the head of the line. The buffet starts by the door that leads from the porch, then follows the counter around the perimeter of the kitchen: sweetcorn (still boiling in the pot) first, then meat and vegetables and mashed potatoes, then casseroles and bread, and desserts and coffee. For those who want it, there is a watermelon on the porch, to be sliced later and eaten outside.

One table is set in the kitchen, others are spread through the ground floor, some under portraits of ancestors. Amid the portraits is a framed deed to the property and a certificate from the state of Ohio confirming a century of continuous ownership. My mother's family lived here through the War of 1812, the Civil War, the First World War, and the Great Depression. My mother was born here in the middle of the Second World War. My father was born on the other side of the county, in another farmhouse.

My mother gave birth to me in a hospital named after an Ohio inventor, in the midst of the Vietnam War, a few weeks after the moon landing of 1969. The Wright Brothers' projects for heavier-than-air flight had been realized a few miles north, in their Dayton bicycle shop.

Dayton was a great American center of innovation and industry. It was the site of the first commercial cargo flight and the first helicopter flight. It became a rail hub in 1900, with dozens of stops at its Union Station each day. Charles Kettering, the hospital's namesake, invented the electric starter for the automobile. He started work at National Cash Register (today NCR), founded DELCO (Dayton Engineering Laboratories Company), and headed research at General Motors.

Along with Wright-Patterson Air Force Base, these three companies were the major local employers in the 1970s, when I was a boy in southwest Ohio. Workers were unionized. The farmers called National Cash Register "the Cash" and Wright-Patterson Air Force Base "the Field" (while the city kids said "NCR" and "Wright-Pat").

Neil Armstrong, the first man to walk on the moon, was from Wapakoneta, Ohio, north of Dayton. As kids we visited his museum there and met him in person. My maternal grandmother had a signed photograph of the astronaut. Her younger brother was a pilot and engineer who worked on the space shuttle; the launch of the Columbia was the ecstatic moment in my childhood. I watched it on television and then went outside to look up at the sky. Heavier-than-air flight in 1903, a moon landing in 1969, a space shuttle in 1981: this trajectory promised a future of adventurous mobility.

My parents grew up on farms in Clinton County, Ohio, before making the leap to Ohio State University. I spent a good deal of my childhood on those farms. During the summer, my paternal grandfather put me and my brothers to work and took us to the county fair. He kept his old baseball bats and gloves by the porch door, as though a game might break out at any moment. I brought my own glove and found ways to practice baseball in the barnyard. The Cincinnati Reds might be playing on television inside while I was playing an imaginary game outside. My paternal grandmother taught me not to cook the sweetcorn too long, shared her historical novels, and was thoughtfully critical about how one spoke. She had taught my father in a one-room schoolhouse.

On the other side of the county, in my maternal grandparents' house, the one with the bell, I liked to take refuge upstairs. Amid my maternal grandmother's fossil collections, I immersed myself in her books about the past, the present, and alternative futures: paleontology, zoology, A Wrinkle in Time.

On New Year's Day 1982, that attic was cold and drafty as I read about the imposition of martial law in communist Poland. In the newspapers, Americans worried about instability and nuclear war, but I had the sense of something lively and interesting. In the photographs in magazines, the gray of armored personnel carriers and dirty snow contrasted with the bit of red ink for the banners of the suppressed labor union, Solidarity.

HolocaustsIn my childhood, the Soviet Union always seemed close, a few minutes' flight by intercontinental ballistic missile. Reader's Digest featured articles on Soviet and American nuclear arsenals. The obsession with the superpowers' destructive capacity was a way to ignore the people who suffered directly in the Cold War, such as the

Latin Americans we kept invading and the east Europeans the Soviets kept invading.

In the 1980s, as social mobility in the United States slowed, talk of nuclear confrontation grew. In 1984 I answered the phone—a landline, of course—and took a survey. The pollster asked me two questions: "Is it safe to work in convenience stores?" and "Are you afraid of nuclear war?" I found nothing strange about that.

American nuclear missiles were called "Minutemen," after the militias of the Revolutionary War. In the 1970s and 1980s, the vision of a nuclear exchange between the United States and the Soviet Union was an element of everyday life. Behind our house (to the west) a meadow stretched all the way to railroad tracks a quarter-mile away, where freight trains passed at sunset when I was a small child. A stream ran through the meadow, watering a little copse where we tried to fish. To the south of our house, across the road, a cornfield rolled uphill to a seminary. A siren atop its bell tower practiced tornado warnings, but the local kids associated it with air raids. Looking up from the creek ("crick") where we were trying to catch crayfish ("crawdads") in Styrofoam cups, we thought of mushroom clouds and knew that it was midday.

It was a shock when my maternal grandmother, Lucile, told me that danger doesn't come from afar. For the fortieth anniversary of D-Day in 1984, a teacher sent me to interview her about the Second World War. Sitting across from me at the kitchen table, Lucile suggested that researching relatives was not the way to understand the war. Herself a teacher, she had taken my school assignment as an opportunity to make sure I learned. She always laughed and offered gumdrops; at fourteen, I scarcely knew what she looked like with a serious expression. That day I found out. Her eyes were wide open, and her cheek muscles taut, as she remonstrated with me about where my thoughts should be. If I was to write about the war, I should remember "all those Jewish people." She sighed and then smiled again.

The Holocaust of the Jews had happened not so very long before. I had read Anne Frank's diary, found by chance on a school bookshelf in fifth grade. Yet at the time when I interviewed my grandmother, the mass murder of the Jews was a smaller part of the memory of the war than it later became. The word Holocaust in this sense came into broad American use after a 1978 television series, but in the 1980s the term was still ambiguous. The Day After, a 1983 made-for-television movie about nuclear holocaust, was watched by one hundred million Americans. One December afternoon in 1985, sitting on an orange couch in the local public library, I listened to some older kids expound upon their plan for nuclear war: get a six-pack, drive to Wright-Pat, and die in the flash rather than from the radiation.

Perhaps that hypothetical nuclear holocaust drew attention away from what the Jewish Holocaust might have taught us. A possible catastrophe involving long-range missiles overshadowed the recent demonstration of how easily a partially democratic system like ours could collapse, how quickly big lies could create restive alternative realities, and how callously humans could kill one another. During the Cold War, American and Soviet propaganda relentlessly associated the other side with the Nazis; the decades of mutual accusation perhaps hardened everyone to the actual risk, which was that fascism might arise at home.

I did have the idea, as a teenager, that fear was making the country less free. When I went to college in 1987, I planned to become a nuclear arms negotiator. Though there was nothing ignoble in this career aim, I was turning away from American reality. I was ignoring the sources of fear that were right in front of me.

BellsIn the late 1980s, as a college student, I was fascinated by people who had found a politics beyond fear: the east European dissidents. Andrei Sakharov, one of the founders of the Soviet nuclear program, was urging Westerners to think less about nuclear intimidation and more about human dignity. I remember raising my eyes from his text and looking up at the sky as the point came home. We should remove the causes of fear if we can; we should also take responsibility for our fears. Freedom cannot be just an absence; it must arise from us and grow into the world.

In the autumn of 1989, during my junior year in college, my planned career in nuclear disarmament was taken away from me. Communism in eastern Europe came to an end, and arms control negotiations with the USSR proceeded quickly to treaties. It was thrilling to read the dispatches of American reporters from eastern Europe. Thanks to a student job at the Center for Foreign Policy Development at Brown University, I met some of the dissidents as they came to power.

I was responsible for the Czechoslovak foreign minister Jiří Dienstbier during some meetings in Washington, failed to get him to any of them on time. He paid no attention to the schedule and kept pausing to have a smoke. We made the vice president and the secretary of state wait. My idea of freedom at that point was all about efficiency, and I was

a little flummoxed that his was so different.

I had written a senior essay on nuclear arms control as a sophomore; as a junior, I focused more on economics, starting projects that would become senior theses on Soviet defense reform and Soviet monopoly. In November 1990, the autumn of my senior year, I was invited to Moscow to present some of my work. It was my first transatlantic flight, following the trajectory of all those imagined missiles. As the aircraft descended, I looked down at a patchwork of collective farms.

This was deep into Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev's period of reform, I was feckless and twenty-one, and I treated the Soviet capital as a place to explore. I dropped the heavily fobbed room key at the reception desk of the Hotel Akademicheskaia and took the fast escalators down to the deep metro platforms that were meant to double as bomb shelters, memorizing station names and asking strangers for help. The hurried glances of fellow passengers, the empty shelves in the stores, the unkempt farmsteads: these impressions confirmed what I had written in my paper, which was that this country would not go on for long.

People did give me directions, which was good; the city was large, the days were cold and short, and the buildings seemed to repeat from district to district. A Russian scholar at the conference kindly took me in, and his two children, about my age, gave me better tours of Moscow. When I spoke tactlessly about the coming collapse of the USSR, their faces showed a simple sadness. They did not doubt it, if the young American scholar said so. But the post-Soviet Russia that they imagined was an empire with a tsar. In the apartment, they showed me treasured relics of the Russian Empire, of a pre-Soviet past.

It was snowing the day the three of us visited the Kremlin. The flakes melted on a bell of improbable size: the "Tsar Bell." It was about as large as the family's apartment and weighed about two hundred tons. Meant to glorify an absolute ruler, the ferrous enormity rested on the ground and did nothing. The songless object got me thinking about the disproportions in the Soviet economy that I was meant to address at the conference in Moscow.

EquilibriumIn the language of physics, a bell that hangs on a post on a farm is in equilibrium: the force of gravity pulling it down is matched by the force of the ground pushing back on the structure. Getting a bell in the air so that it can be rung requires some careful work. Not every equilibrium is the same. The Tsar Bell is in an equilibrium in which it cannot be rung.

Economists also speak of equilibria. They like situations when things seem to be in balance, as the result of an aggregate of human actions that can be characterized as a larger, impersonal force. For example: supply, the amount of stuff, is supposed to balance demand, how much people want that stuff. An equilibrium is like a happy ending: everything turns out right. We don't have to think about people as individuals with purposes: markets do the thinking for us. We do not have to ask how people come into the world, why they want what they want, or what it means to be free.

In autumn 1990, when I traveled to the Soviet Union, I was working on projects in economics, but that semester I was also taking graduate classes in history and had applied for a fellowship to continue those studies in a doctoral program. I liked history's inexhaustibility—a surprise awaited in each new book, behind each half-understood event, within each new language. The past is full of wild possibilities that were actually realized, such as the Bolshevik Revolution, or the American one. The east European revolutions of 1989, unpredictable as they had been, made me wonder whether other surprises might be coming.

In Moscow in November 1990, history gave me a common language with Soviet scholars. We talked about the Russian economy in the late imperial years, before the revolution, and about the crash industrialization of the 1930s. I could agree with Soviet participants that the problem of transforming their planned economy into something else was not foreseen in textbook economics.

In the cold and drafty conference room, my mind wandering, I doodled little bells in the margins of my notes. In the Russian Empire, in 1591 and 1771, bells had been sentenced to Siberian exile, on the theory that they precipitated public gatherings. In 1510, after Moscow conquered the town of Pskov, the new rulers did away with the bell used to call public meetings.

I drew some manacles around the bells. In the Soviet Union, as I knew from my own research on Soviet monopoly,

Pskov was where they made all the handcuffs. (In 2014 troops from Pskov invaded Ukraine; in 2022 they murdered civilians at Bucha.) The rest of the Soviet economy was similarly centralized: critical products were made in a few sites or even in a single factory. Natural gas and oil were also extracted and distributed in a very centralized way.

As an initial condition for a market economy, I was trying to say, monopoly was unpromising. Capitalism's radical critics (Vladimir Lenin) and radical supporters (Friedrich Hayek) agreed that monopoly meant oppression. Markets are supposed to enable competition, spread information, and separate economics from politics. But what would happen when giant Soviet enterprises came into private hands?

Monopolists would seek to prevent competition, own media, and corner political power. Once the Soviet Union began to come apart (I was arguing), its industrial concentration would accelerate the process of disintegration, because locals who seized control of valuable assets would seek to protect their new holdings by trying to control new states.

So any shift to capitalism in the Soviet Union had to be understood as part of a longer political history, not as a clearing of the slate that would generate perfect markets. From the starting point of the Soviet reality around me in November 1990, laissez-faire was not going to lead to the right result. Oligarchy, rule by the very wealthy, is also an equilibrium. A heavy bell can just stay on the ground.

I don't think I managed to get much of this across in Moscow: the huge meeting room turned all utterances into echoes; men in scarves shivered during the presentations; the secondhand cigarette smoke was uncannily warmer than the air.

No one was thinking much then about the non-Russian nations. Americans said "Russia" for the USSR and "Russians" for Soviet citizens. I was little better, though I knew the geography from studying military sites and big factories. Half of the population of the Soviet Union was not Russian, and a quarter of the territory was in the non-Russian republics. The Russian republic itself was described as a federation because of its tremendous variety: it contained, for example, the Tatars, one of the largest Soviet nationalities. Ukraine was, after Russia, the second-largest in population. In Moscow, American conference participants saw the opera Mazepa, about the Ukrainian hetman and his break with Tsar Peter; during the intermission, the economists in the group asked the Russia hands whether Ukraine was a separate country. Not really, was the consensus.

Jet-lagged and reading at night for a college seminar on Marxism, I thought in Moscow about the uncanny similarity between the prophets of communism and the prophets of capitalism. Capitalists knew that communist societies would automatically right themselves once private property was restored, just as Marxists had once known that capitalist societies would automatically right themselves once private property was abolished. I felt the draw of the first view: Would it not be nice to simply start again, free of the past? But the appeal was just too similar to the confidence of Marx and Engels, or for that matter that of Lenin and Trotsky when the Soviet experiment began.

I worked as a student at the Center for Foreign Policy Development between spring 1989 and spring 1991, in Washington at Foreign Policy magazine in summer 1990, and in Washington again at the Institute for International Economics in the summer and autumn of 1991. I had a sense of the elite consensus between the end of communism in eastern Europe in late 1989 and the disintegration of the Soviet Union in late 1991. Very few of the wise heads expected either. The George H. W. Bush administration supported Gorbachev to the very last moment. U.S. policy was to hold the Soviet Union together. President Bush went to Kyiv on August 1, 1991, but only to urge Ukrainians not to declare independence.

On August 18, 1991, I went to bed early in my Georgetown sublet. I had worked all day on Russian economics and German language, then made a meal for some friends to celebrate my twenty-second birthday. A Russian friend awakened me with a telephone call: "Massive revolution!" He meant the coup attempt against Gorbachev that would be the beginning of the end of the USSR. Ukrainian communists declared the independence of their republic on August 24. A month later, I finished my study of Soviet monopoly and departed for graduate study in history at Oxford. The formal dissolution of the USSR in December found me in Czechoslovakia. Right after New Year's, I took the night train from Prague to Warsaw. When I presented a paper on Soviet monopoly in Vienna in April 1992, the economists from what had been the USSR now represented newly independent states.

As the Soviet Union came to an end, American anxiety yielded to an odd euphoria. Americans hadn't expected

revolution and disintegration. And yet many were now speaking with confidence about what must follow: a durable capitalist equilibrium would bring with it democracy and freedom. In fairness, the better economists were concerned about structures. But negative freedom set the tone: once the barriers of Soviet central planning and state ownership were cleared away, only good things could follow. This odd confidence about the future was one reason I decided to study the past.

ExceptionalismThe Cold War had been a moral challenge for the United States. Anti-communism led to the denunciatory excesses of McCarthyism. It also became a justification for supporting right-wing dictators, invading Caribbean and Latin American countries, and overthrowing democratically elected rulers.

I was brought up in this knowledge. My parents had been serving in the Peace Corps in the Dominican Republic when the United States intervened in 1965. They were then transferred to El Salvador. A Salvadoran girl spent six months at our home when I was small, taking care of my brothers and me. My mother kept visiting Latin America throughout my childhood, and she taught Latin American studies at a local university.

The Soviet challenge had also pushed America toward some strengths. It led to the moon shot of 1969 and to important technological spin-offs. It encouraged Americans to engage with European and Russian culture, and it brought government investment to universities, including in languages and the humanities. American universities taught classes on Russia and the Soviet Union (though rarely on eastern Europe and almost never on Ukraine). Avant-garde American art, music, and literature were propagated abroad, to show that democracy could be hip and vibrant. Soviet reminders of American inequality bolstered the American welfare state and helped the civil rights movement. So long as Marxism was a present alternative, Americans tried to justify their own system with ideas and safeguard it with structures.

The disintegration of the USSR in 1991 was like a judo move, turning the United States against itself. Arguments gave way to verities: capitalism would replace communism and bring democracy to the world. As negative freedom became common sense in the United States, one determinism replaced another. If the absence of private property had not brought freedom, then the presence of private property surely would. Since the iron laws of history would liberate everyone, there was no need to know the past—even the details of communism and fascism, the two great political alternatives of the twentieth century, could be forgotten. At the moment I chose history, it was deemed irrelevant. And yet freedom must be about possible futures, and any possible future exists on a line from an actual past. How were we to draw those lines without history?

OligarchyUnexpected events did take place in the early 1990s: racial violence in Los Angeles, which I read about in Polish newspapers as I was learning the language on the Baltic coast; the billionaire Ross Perot's first campaign for president, which became real for me on a BBC electoral map in an Oxford common room; the Yugoslav wars, which drove refugees to Vienna, where I befriended a few of them. Yet in this mood, each crisis seemed exceptional, and each challenge seemed technical. History was not to be learned but blamed—ethnic cleansing in the Balkans was supposedly a result of "ancient hatreds." America was to be the timeless measure of freedom.

If freedom is negative, then politics becomes the practical work of clearing away the junk of the past: in the jargon of the 1980s and 1990s: deregulation, privatization, welfare reform. Economics or nature is expected to do the rest. The conception of freedom as negative led Americans to give bad advice to east Europeans: privatize as quickly as possible; portray the welfare state as a communist deformation; ignore culture. It also led the United States to some dreadful domestic policies in the 1990s, such as the prison industrial complex and wealth hoarding.

Negative freedom also hovered over errors of the 2000s. After spending a few more years in eastern Europe, I moved in September 2001 to New Haven, Connecticut, for my first real job, at Yale University. I was in New York in the early morning hours of September 11 (to watch the Yankees lose to the Orioles in a long, ugly game delayed by rain). When I learned in New Haven what had happened, I tried to return to New York, but the trains had stopped running.

The attacks of 9/11 were presented as something unprecedented, the dawn of a new world in which freedom must be sacrificed for safety. At my very first class at Yale, I talked about the destruction of the Twin Towers in the light of what I understood from east European episodes of terror and counterterror. A provocation works when a less powerful entity turns a more powerful actor against itself. The attack of 9/11 was one of the most successful provocations of all time.

After 9/11, Americans were told that the attackers "hate freedom," but our response suggested that we misunderstood it. The ostensible exchange of freedom for security meant less of each. Surveillance became normal. The 2003 invasion of Iraq killed hundreds of thousands of Iraqis and left the United States poorer, less secure, and less trusted. That war was an adventure in negative freedom, waged to create an absence. Destroying the Iraqi state and dissolving the ruling party and army, it was assumed, would automatically bring capitalism and democracy. It did not. The war strengthened Iran and created a series of security problems that extended deep into the new century.

Our misunderstanding of Russia in the 1990s and 2000s also had to do with negative freedom. In 1993 the Russian president, Boris Yeltsin, had dissolved the Russian parliament by force. This was understood in the United States as necessary for economic reform. In fact, Soviet industrial concentration was becoming capitalist monopoly. A few people were taking control of the profitable enterprises. After 1999, Yeltsin's handpicked successor, Vladimir Putin, became the boss of bosses, consolidating power through terror and wars.

Seen through the lens of negative freedom, Putin seemed like a technocrat interested in money. The assumption was that wealth would bring rationality, and rationality would bring democracy. During my first spring at Yale, I was invited to a meeting where a major international hydrocarbon firm was being advised about Russia. A colleague with experience at high levels of government said that U.S. policy was grounded in the assumption that capitalism would bring democracy to both Russia and China. I said that this was absurd. I was not invited to such meetings for a while.

Russian oligarchy instead brought a new politics, an alternative during an epoch when there were supposed to be no alternatives. In 2004, Putin's Russia attempted to rig the vote in Ukraine. Ten years later, it invaded southern and eastern Ukraine. Before and during the invasion, Moscow's propaganda slandered Ukraine and Ukrainians. The basis of the attack was not evidence or even ideology, but rather estimations of what would arouse negative emotions in consumers of social media. Knowing something about what people believed about the world, Russia could target specific vulnerabilities. Considered in their totality, Russia's claims about Ukraine were contradictory: there was no Ukrainian language, but the Ukrainian state was making everyone speak it; the Ukrainian state did not exist but was repressive; Ukrainians were all Nazis, but they were also gays and Jews. I was living in Vienna at the time and was in contact with Ukrainian friends and colleagues. The simple fact that Russia had invaded a neighboring country got lost in social media. Americans and others wasted outrage on phantoms even as a real war of aggression began.

In Russia, we see the transition from the definition of freedom as the lack of barriers to a politics of fascism in which there are no barriers to the Leader's whims. Yet Moscow's own propaganda position—that nothing is true and nothing is good—was not perceived as a danger. The invasion of Ukraine demonstrated the fallacy of economic determinism: oligarchic Russia was an aggressive empire, not an emerging democracy. For people who believed that freedom was negative, Russian nihilism did not seem hazardous. It was, of course. Any vacuum of facts and values will be filled with spectacle and war. The fascist nature of the Russian regime ought to have been clear well before Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022.

The Russian case might serve as a warning. In the twenty-first century, American capitalism has also been driven toward monopoly, wealth concentration, and decadence. When we think that we are exceptional in our devotion to freedom, our overconfidence makes us vulnerable to the propaganda of tyrants pitched at what we want to hear. If we believe that freedom is negative, the problem is only a barrier outside, and never our own lack of judgment. When I returned to the United States in 2014 after a year away, I was struck (as were my Ukrainian and Russian friends) by how well Russian social media functioned in American politics. That Americans had been fooled by Russia about Ukraine was bad enough. But in 2015 and 2016 Americans were fooled by Russians about other Americans. In 2016 the oligarchical American presidential candidate won, with Russian assistance.

Donald Trump, Putin's submissive client, is a hero of negative freedom, wealthy through undertaxed inheritance and comfortable denying everything. In 2018 he traveled to Helsinki and told the world that he trusted a Russian dictator more than his American advisers. In 2019 he tried to bully an elected Ukrainian president to get dirt on his rival in the coming presidential election. When Trump lost the election of 2020, he lied about the outcome and tried to stage a coup d'état to stay in power. Despite a constitutional ban on insurrectionists holding office, he purports to be running for president in 2024, keeping alive Putin's hopes that he can win his war in Ukraine.

Deep into a century that was the stuff of dreams in the 1970s, and the subject of confident predictions in the 1990s,

we find ourselves at a turning point. Whether we will be free will depend on us—not just on what we do, but on why we do it: our ideals.

StayingWithout ideals, it is impossible to be a realist. If you forget about freedom, you misunderstand the world and change it for the worse. The initial American reaction to Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 clarifies the point.

As Russia massed its troops on the Ukrainian border, I was in New Haven, where I had been teaching for two decades. On the Monday before Russia's full-scale invasion, I took part in a remote meeting, a doctoral dissertation defense in Ukraine. Illia Chedoluma was defending a history thesis about a Ukrainian literary critic of Jewish origin who translated Hamlet while hiding from the Nazis. Illia passed his exam, then enlisted in the Ukrainian territorial defense.

On the Tuesday before Russia invaded, I was invited to join a class at Yale's School of Management. The colleague leading the class had seen me on television the prior Sunday and knew that I held an unusual opinion about Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelens'kyi: that if Russia invaded, he would stay, and that Ukraine would fight. My colleague had invited security advisers to former presidents Barack Obama and Donald Trump to participate remotely in the class, and he asked them to comment on my prediction. Talking down from the big screens, they all disagreed with me. For them, it was self-evident that Zelens'kyi would flee. Like the people inside the Kremlin, the people inside the Beltway believed that Ukraine would fall in three days. The Russian and American conventional wisdom was identical.

On the Thursday, Russia invaded, and my student reported to his unit. Zelens'kyi stayed in Kyiv, and Ukrainians fought. The American experts had excluded freedom as a factor in the world, so their prediction was incorrect. They had patiently explained that Zelens'kyi would leave the country; American intelligence officers advised him to do so. All were representing an American consensus. Americans had told themselves for decades that freedom was negative, that it represented a clearing-away of barriers by larger forces. If you believe in the primacy of the larger forces, then you have no choice when they seem to turn against you: you run. And you cannot imagine that others would behave any differently.

On the Friday, Zelens'kyi posted a video of himself and other high government officials in Kyiv: "The president is here." This was a transformative example of the freedom of speech. Like freedom in general, freedom of speech is not negative but positive, not about the barriers but the person, not about an absence but a presence. We protect free speakers because truth threatens the power of tyrants. Zelens'kyi was speaking truth amid the lies of Russian propagandists who claimed that he had abandoned the city. He was speaking his truth to power, because Russia was invading with terrifying force. Zelens'kyi was putting his body at risk for what he knew to be true. Indeed, it was what he was doing with his body—staying—that was the truth.

His refusal to leave gives a hint of what positive freedom—true freedom—might be. Barriers to freedom were no doubt present, in a most radical form. Even as Zelens'kyi spoke, Russian assassins were tracking him. The Russian army was at the gates of Kyiv, Russian bombs and missiles were falling, and virtually everyone outside Ukraine expected Russia to win the war within hours or days. And yet for Ukrainians, it was not so much the objects that were the issue—the bullets and the explosives—but the intention behind them, the elimination of a society. Russian weapons had to be met with Ukrainian weapons, but they also had to be met with commitment. The Ukrainians defeated the Russians at Kyiv and then at Kharkiv. Bucha would be de-occupied, Yahidne and Posad Pokrovs'ke as well, within a year after Russia's full-scale invasion. Ukrainians would regain more than half of the land Russia took in February 2022. But only because people decided to stay.

When I asked Zelens'kyi why he had remained in Kyiv, he said that he "could not have done otherwise." Explaining his choice, he began not from the specific predicament, dramatic though it was, and not even from himself. He spoke of his love for his parents, and what he had learned from them. He had not chosen them, and yet in his love for them he was free. He compared that love to the decision to remain in the capital as the war began: something self-evident. Staying was not something he did alone: he was in the company of those who had taught him when he was younger and those who had elected him. He was in the company of others who were also taking risks. He understood the situation, he said, because of what it meant to represent others. A president, he said, was only the first grain of sand in a turning hourglass.

We talked about how, over time, beginning in youth, an accumulation of decisions makes us who we are. Then a moment comes when we do what we must because of what we have chosen to become. An unfree person can always try to run. But sometimes a free person has to stay. Free will is character.

SovereigntyLeibThe German philosopher Edith Stein put her own body forward during the First World War. A graduate student, she took leave to volunteer as a nurse. When she returned to her dissertation, her time with the wounded guided her argument about empathy. “Do we not,” she asked, “need the mediation of the body to assure ourselves of the existence of another person?”

The word she used for “body” was Leib.

The first form of freedom, as I hope to show, is sovereignty. A sovereign person knows themselves and the world sufficiently to make judgments about values and to realize those judgments.

For Stein, we gain knowledge of ourselves when we acknowledge others. Only when we recognize that other people are in the same predicament as we are, live as bodies as we do, can we take seriously how they see us. When we identify with them as they regard us, we understand ourselves as we otherwise might not. Our own objectivity, in other words, depends on the subjectivity of others.

This is not how we are accustomed to seeing things. We imagine that we can just take in information ourselves, as isolated individuals. We believe that when we are alone, we are free. This mistake ensures that we are not.

The word Leib gets us to a new standpoint. The German language has two terms for “body,” Körper and Leib. The word Körper can denote a person’s body but also a “foreign body” (Fremdkörper), a “heavenly body” (Himmelskörper), the “racial body” (Volkskörper), and other objects thought to be subject to physical laws. A Körper might be alive, but it need not be (compare corpse). Stein says, “There can be a Körper without me, but no Leib without me.”

The word Leib designates a living human body, or an animal body, or the body of an imaginary creature in a story. A Leib is a Körper, subject to physical laws, but that is not all it is. It has its own rules and so its own opportunities. A Leib can move, a Leib can feel, and a Leib has its own center, impossible to graph precisely in space, which Stein calls a “zero point.” We can always see some of our Leib, but we can never see all of it.

Our liveliness is shared. When we understand another person as Leib rather than Körper, we see the whole world differently. The other person has a zero point, just as we do; those zero points make connections, creating a new web of understanding. It is thanks to the Leib of another that we are liberated from thinking of ourselves as outside the world, or against the world. A little leap of empathy is at the beginning of the knowledge we need for freedom.

If it is just me against the world, then all my grumpy late-night pronouncements are justified and true and deserving of attention. But let us imagine that my daughter (also) gets cranky when she is tired and says entirely unreasonable things. Seeing her, seeing that, I recognize a phenomenon in the world, and suddenly know more about myself. That example I owe to questioning from my son about the argument of this book. Knowing me and knowing his sister, he immediately knew what I meant, and then he could also see that this is objective knowledge, of the kind we cannot get alone.

Thanks to the Leib, phenomena come into view, those that are essential for life and for freedom: birth, sleep, waking, health, breathing, eating, drinking, sheltering, lovemaking, illness, aging, death. None of us remembers being born, but all of us were born. None of us will remember dying, but we remember others dying. Empathy is not just some vague urging to be kind. Empathy is a precondition for certain knowledge of the world. The isolated individual, trying to contemplate the world alone, has no chance of understanding it.

Because the Leib is at the source of knowledge, it is also at the source of a politics of freedom. When we see other people as subjects like ourselves, we begin to gain objective knowledge about the world. If we see others as objects, we will lack essential knowledge not only about them but also about the world and about ourselves. This makes us vulnerable to those who would abuse us and rule us. We will see ourselves as objects, and we will be manipulated by others who treat us as such.

In this light, negative freedom is the self-deception of people who do not really wish to be free. Those who present freedom as negative ignore what we are, ignore the Leib. If we are just Körper, physical bodies, then the idea of negative freedom would make a kind of sense. Objects can be restrained by other objects. Freedom could just be freedom from, without aspirations or individuality, without any sense of what life is or should be. But when we correctly apprehend ourselves as a body in a human sense, as a Leib, we understand that freedom must suit that special state. It must be positive, not negative. Barriers are bad not because they block us as objects, but because they hinder us from understanding one another and becoming subjects.

Negative freedom is not a misunderstanding but a repressive idea. It is itself a barrier, a barrier of an intellectual and moral kind. It blocks us from seeing what we would need to be free. Those who want us unfree create barriers between us, or dissuade us from building the structures that would allow understanding. When we see ourselves as Leib, and understand the world, we see what we would have to build together in order to become free.

LifeEdith Stein only ever held one university job, for a single academic year. She lost it when Adolf Hitler came to power. In April 1933 she wrote a letter to the pope, in which she tried to explain, in language he would understand, the position of Germany's Jews: "We have seen deeds perpetrated in Germany which mock any sense of justice and humanity, not to mention love of neighbor." She called the Church's silence about Jewish oppression a "black mark" on its history.

Hitler took a view of the human body utterly opposed to Stein's. In Mein Kampf, he wrote of Fremdkörper, "foreign bodies," infesting the Volkskörper, the German racial organism. Rather than seeing each person in Germany as a distinct human body, Nazis portrayed the German race as a single organism and the Jews as the foreign objects, bacteria or parasites.

When my children were smaller, we lived in Vienna. When my daughter was in first grade and my son in third, we commuted to school on scooters across the Heldenplatz, where a huge crowd had welcomed Hitler just before Germany annexed Austria. That year I took my son to soccer practice in a stadium twice a week. One day, the coaches passed out violet jerseys, Leibchen, a word that sounds like "little body." The boys threw off what they were wearing, pushed their arms and heads into their new shirts, and suddenly looked like a team.

Five years before that, when we waited for the bus for kindergarten, my then-three-year-old son was fascinated by the machines used to dig into the sidewalk and to spread tar on the exposed areas. The workers were preparing to lay Stolpersteine, "stumbling stones," palpable memorials to murdered Jews. These inscribed metal plates, embedded in the pavement, remind us of where Jews once lived. The information they carry—names, addresses, sites of death—give us a chance to rehumanize, to restore, at least in imagination, what they lost. Before the Jews were killed, they were stripped of everything: first their property, then their clothes. Like the million or so other Jews murdered at Auschwitz, Edith Stein had to disrobe. This was theft, of course, but mainly humiliation, treating a Leib as a Körper, preparing everyone for murder.

Before my son's birth in Vienna, German was for me a language of death: of Hitler's speech at the Heldenplatz, of the sign over the gates of Auschwitz, of all the thousands of sources I had read in order to write about the Holocaust and other atrocities. Körper in all its forms was familiar, Leib less so. With my son, German became a language of life. I heard the word Leib in a Vienna maternity ward, from a nurse trying to teach breastfeeding.

Mothers remain in Austrian hospitals for ninety-six hours after giving birth, to learn to wash and feed the baby. In that space with those bodies for four days, I learned things I would not otherwise have known. The predicament of nurse, mother, and infant was different from mine, but I could understand something about it, then about myself and the world. I am freer as a father for having been there.

Your Leib pushes back into the world, changing it. It translates physics into pain and pleasure, chemistry into desire and disappointment, biology into poetry and prose. It is the permeable membrane between necessity and freedom. It is a Leib that is capable of the kind of concentration that marks a free and sovereign person. Körper we concentrate in a camp.

NeighborStein was unable, as a woman in interwar Germany, to earn the credential and keep the job that would have suited her. After publishing her dissertation on empathy, she turned her energy to publishing the work of a friend and teacher who had been killed in battle, and then to editing that of Edmund Husserl, their supervisor. Husserl

wrote letters of recommendation to the effect that she ought to be a professor of philosophy were it an appropriate role for women.

Jewish by upbringing, Stein had converted to Catholicism. After Hitler came to power and she lost her academic job, she took orders as a nun. Recasting her philosophy in biblical terms can help us see what is special about our bodies. Unlike contemporary German, Martin Luther's first German translation of the Bible always uses Leib for the human body. As a Leib, we are neither gods nor objects, but nor are we just a dilution, something in between. The universe neither gives nor denies us freedom. It sets before us restraints that we can know, and it offers us the possibility of adding something new.

Because we are imperfect, we see the universe in ways appropriate to the limits of the human body. This is positional knowledge that God cannot have. Unlike God, we can choose to see ourselves and the world through others of our own kind. A familiar biblical verse makes Stein's point about knowledge through the Leib of another: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12).

God has no Leib and is aware of the attendant limitations: "My spirit shall not always strive with man, for that he also is flesh" (Genesis 6:3). Stein put it this way: "We have to admit that if God rejoiced over the repentance of a sinner, he would experience no pounding of the heart."

Our hearts do pound from excitement or exertion. Unlike God, we can be free, in the precise sense of turning the restraints of our universe into opportunities. God knows no adversity, and adversity has uses. Facing a law of necessity He does not face, we expand a law of freedom He does not know. And so:

The limits of an object are its limits.

The capabilities of God are His capabilities.

The limits of a Leib are its capabilities.

Jesus of Nazareth certainly had a Leib. He forgave the sins of a weeping woman who "began to wash his feet with her tears, and did wipe them with the hairs of her head" (Luke 7:38). When Jesus says that "the spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak" (Matthew 26:41), we can relate. He suffered physical pain and knew that he would die. Unlike God the Father, Jesus is neither litigious nor vengeful, emphasizing instead the simple laws of loving God and loving one's neighbor.

Whereas God quickly lost patience with his creations, exposing their imperfection by killing them, Jesus spoke patiently in riddles and allegories, forcing his listeners to think again. When asked whom we should regard as our neighbor, he told a story about a suffering Leib.

In the parable of the Good Samaritan, a Jew who has been "stripped of his raiment" is lying "wounded" beside the road. Other Jews walk by and do not help him. A non-Jew, a Samaritan, recognized the injured Jew as a fellow person, "had compassion on him" (Luke 10:30–33), tended his wounds, and found him shelter. Who is thy neighbor? He that showed mercy. Go and do likewise.

In the story, it is the Samaritan who is free. He is sovereign, in that he is acting according to his own values and is able to realize them in the world. The road that he walked was material, but not only. We are in nature but not entirely of it. Our bodies are subject to inertia, but we can choose to stop by the side of the road. Our bodies are pulled down by gravity, but we can raise someone else up from the ditch.

MysteryFor the French philosopher Simone Weil, acknowledging the existence of another was an act of love. For her, loving one's neighbor as oneself meant reading "the same combination of nature and the supernatural" in another person's body that we experience ourselves.

The Bible also asks us to love "the stranger that dwelleth among you" as we love ourselves (Leviticus 19:34). "To love a stranger as oneself implies," says Weil, "that we love ourselves as strangers." Like many of her formulations, this one is a challenge. It is not just that we do right when we love a stranger. It is that we see ourselves as a stranger might see us, see what is strange in us, which is what we need to see. When we see ourselves as others see us, we

know ourselves better. This is liberating. We experience the restraints of the external world and push against them, in the company of others who are doing the same. We are free when we know in which direction we wish to push and how we can do so.

Weil felt the restraints acutely. She suffered from migraines and physical awkwardness. That one academic year when Stein was able to teach, 1932–33, Weil spent in Germany. In 1934–35 Weil worked as a machinist and a packer in factories in France, to understand workers; the labor exhausted her. She volunteered to fight in the Spanish Civil War in 1936 but injured herself immediately. During the Second World War, working in London for the French Resistance, she asked to be sent to occupied Europe with a group of nurses. Her supreme commander, Charles de Gaulle, thought she was crazy. Weil had trouble eating and died of illness during the war.

Weil called our bodies "a source of mystery that we cannot eliminate." We are here as our bodies or not at all; we are free as our bodies or not at all. In notebooks that she kept during the war, Weil wrote of gravity and grace. We are a special sort of creature, subject to the laws of physics but able to understand them—and to bend them to purposes that are not reducible to them. The body wends its way between the world of things as they are and the world of things as they might be. Weil's "mystery" was the presence of the body in both realms, the is and the ought. To be sovereign means to have a sense of what ought to be and how to get there.

StadiumSimone Weil liked sports. She thought that physical coordination enables "thought to enter into direct contact with things." Practice creates, she thought, "a second nature, better than the first." Like Weil, I was a poor athlete by nature, so I had to practice. I can swim thanks to a local swim club and instructors and a patient mother reading novels poolside. I could never do all the things in gym class that other kids found easy, so I trained myself. My mother recalls my jumping rope in the garage by myself for hours each day. I excelled at baseball because it was a sport I could practice alone or with my father.

As a kid, I loved to watch baseball live. It was a special treat to be in the stadium, my body with other bodies. I played the game and so could identify with the players. I idolized the Cincinnati Reds, the Big Red Machine of the 1970s. I played make-believe games of baseball with a friend, batting as all the Reds players, imitating their stances.

The 1975 World Series between the Reds and the Boston Red Sox is the first I remember. In game one, the winning pitcher for the Red Sox was the ageless Afro-Cuban Luis Tiant. During the game, which I watched on television, one of the commentators mentioned that Tiant had worried about raising his son in the United States. I was barely six and not sure what the word prejudice meant.

A stadium is a site of education. The word comes from Greek and has to do with a fixed measurement. A stadium is an objectively defined site where intensely subjective things happen. In a group bigger than we can count, we learn things that we later find difficult to question. At Riverfront Stadium in Cincinnati, I learned the national anthem, "The Star-Spangled Banner." I can't remember not knowing the lyrics.

Awed by British cannon during the War of 1812, Francis Scott Key asked:

O say does that star-spangled banner yet wave

O'er the land of the free and the home of the brave?

The Reds brought together talented white, Black, and Latin American players. I don't think I ever asked myself what it might mean for African American players to stand for a song about liberty that was written when their ancestors were enslaved. I do remember wondering what it meant for the players who were not American to stand for the anthem of another country.

Considering the Leib of others (as Stein put it), or seeing the strangers among us (as Weil said), we attune ourselves differently. Thinking about that physical act of standing at attention from other perspectives, we hear the anthem's lyrics differently. The questions it poses become less rhetorical: Does the American flag wave today? Most assuredly it does. This is the easy part. But does it fly over "the land of the free"?

It is easy to imagine that freedom will be brought to us by a song, by jets over a stadium, by the land, by the ancestors, by the Founders, by capitalism. But is the notion that we are granted freedom right for a "home of the

brave”? Is it not more courageous to ask what Americans have done, could have done, should do?

We say that a symbol stands for something, but all too often a symbol merely stands in for something. The American flag is supposed to stand for freedom, but it can very easily stand in for freedom. In singing the anthem, we treat its values as permanent, or as if they were enacted by song. But praise is not practice.

By no meaningful index are Americans today among the freest peoples of the world. An American organization, Freedom House, measures freedom by the criteria Americans prefer: civil and political liberties. Year after year about fifty countries do better than us on these measures.

Our northern neighbor Canada stands far above us. In a recent ranking, the United States shared a place with South Korea (a country Americans fought for), Romania (a post-communist country that few Americans would see as a peer), and Panama (a country that the United States called into existence in order to get a canal built).

The truth about the “land of the free” is more sobering still. Most of the countries with higher rankings than ours in civil and political liberties would surpass us by still greater margins in the measures that their citizens would consider elements of freedom, such as access to health care. If such measures were included, we would fall even further down on the scale.

The countries where people tend to think of freedom as freedom to are doing better by our own measures, which tend to focus on freedom from. That should give pause for thought. Political systems that are oriented toward freedom to are doing better than we are on freedom from. This suggests that there is no contradiction between the two. Indeed, it suggests that freedom to comes first. That is not what we are used to thinking or want to think. It helps to look at others if we want to understand ourselves.

We tend to think of freedom just as freedom from, as negative. But conceiving of freedom as an escape or an evasion does not tell us what freedom is nor how it would be brought into the world. Freedom to, positive freedom, involves thinking about who we want to become. What do we value? How do we realize our values in the world? If we don’t think of freedom as positive, we won’t even get freedom in the negative sense, since we will be unable to tell what is in fact a barrier, how barriers can be taken in hand and become tools, and how tools extend our freedom.

Freedom from is a conceptual trap. It is also a political trap, in that it involves self-deception, contains no program for its own realization, and offers opportunities to tyrants. Both a philosophy and a politics of freedom have to begin with freedom to.

Freedom is positive. It is about holding virtues in mind and having some power to realize them. Insofar as such a thing can be measured, Americans could be doing better. As I write, in self-reported well-being, Americans are fifteenth in the world. In about fifty countries, people live longer lives.

DeathNot long after I reached the age of fifty years, it seemed that I would die. When I was close to death, I thought about baseball.

One of my clearest memories from childhood is the first home run I hit, at the age of thirteen, in May 1983. The team uniforms were baby blue and navy, the white lettering advertising a local orthodontist. The team was stacked with talent at almost every position. That day we were playing on one of the few local fields that had a fence. The pitch to me was a fastball down and on the inside half of the plate, but too close to the middle. I stepped, turned on the ball just right, and hit it. The left fielder turned, took a step, and watched it clear the fence. The ball bounced on the asphalt of the parking lot and disappeared into the woods. My teammates whooped.

What I remember is the way the bat felt in my hands when I struck the ball. I knew that I had hit it just right. I had that feeling of rightness on my palms, in my wrists, up my arms, and into my thin chest. I was an alienated teenager who could program a computer; earlier that year, in school, I had created a game called “Lifegame” and was excited and then a little disturbed by how it could take over players’ attention. I had been obsessed since early childhood with the possibility that everything could be a simulation and that therefore I was not really alive.

But when the bat hit the ball, I knew that I was.

In moments of distress, my body calls for that memory, as it did during a serious illness in late 2019. That December

an infection of my appendix spread to my liver and then to my blood, bringing about the often-lethal condition known as sepsis. As my body's immune system tried to resist, it attacked my own nerves. My hands felt hot and tingled intensely, as though I were wearing mittens of heated steel wool.

At year's end, in an emergency room in New Haven, I could feel my body floating between Leib and Körper. When I closed my eyes, I saw things that weren't there. The burning that I felt had no connection to the world outside. I was exhausted and breathing hard, but not because of any effort I had made.

Some of the fault was mine. I had been raised to think of the body as just one more external constraint, to be resisted. Pain was to be ignored. If I injured myself during a game, I was never to touch where it hurt. And so when my appendix burst on December 3 during a visit to Germany, my first impulse had been to pay no attention. I was in the German welfare state to attend a board meeting and discuss a hospital, but somehow none of that seemed directly relevant to me.

I was also to give a lecture in Munich that evening on the question "Can the United States Become a Free Country?" I did it, covering my discomfort by telling jokes, and the pain seemed to release me from inhibitions. After the lecture, I found I was not very hungry and left dinner early for the hotel. I went to bed, but then the thought of my distant family induced me to call a cab and go to a hospital. I was proud of myself for doing that. Once there, though, I did not complain enough. The doctors released me with the wrong diagnosis and without prescribing antibiotics. I went to my board meeting.

If freedom is just negative, an absence of barriers, then the body comes into the story negatively, as just one more restraint. My own unfortunate attitude toward my body was consistent with a broader American mistake.

From regarding the body as an object, it is a short step to regarding it as a commodity. It seems normal in the United States to see the body as a source of profit. And that was my next problem.

I flew home from Germany with a burst appendix and peritonitis, then managed (at my wife's urgings) to go to the doctor a second time. After being seen on December 15, I was referred to a New Haven hospital. This time the burst appendix was diagnosed, as was a lesion on my liver. But in their haste to get me out the door after the appendectomy, the doctors forgot about the liver. I left with an insufficient prescription for antibiotics and no referral for the liver abscess, about which I knew nothing at the time. (I learned about the detection of the liver growth long after the fact, reading my own medical records.) The infection then spilled into my blood.

RaceOne problem was me; another was commercial medicine; a third was race. In the emergency room in New Haven on December 29, I needed a Good Samaritan, I needed someone to recognize me through my body, and I had such a person. Her presence, sad to say, might have made things worse.

The physician friend who met me at the emergency room had no trouble seeing my Leib. We had run a race together in a thunderstorm. My convulsive trembling and high fever meant something to her. She understood that it was hard for me to communicate pain. She was not sure what was wrong, but she knew that my body needed more attention than it was getting. She spent the night in a chair beside me.

When my friend spoke up for me, though, she was deflected. Her colleagues saw the color of her skin rather than hearing her words. It was a cold December night, and she was wearing a purple fleece zipped up to her neck. I kept thinking that if only she would pull her hospital badge from behind that fleece, her colleagues might see her as a doctor rather than as a Black person. The nurse, the resident, and the attending physician set themselves up in opposition to my friend. If my friend said I was very ill, they were predisposed to think the contrary. They took my body less seriously than they should have. I almost lost my life—or, as people say in German, my Leib und Leben.

After more errors, I was eventually diagnosed with sepsis and treated for it; after a few more weeks and much more bungling, the liver infection subsided as well. Once I could walk around, I did. As in most American hospitals, there was nowhere really to go. So I walked up and down the corridor: one lap at first, eventually ten laps, twenty.

I needed to move. One day a nurse touched my arm as I was making my rounds and whispered to me that I was doing the right thing, as though the pursuit of happiness were a secret we shared.

HappinessHaving nearly died in that American hospital, I gave some thought, pacing its corridors, to the “right to life.” In the Declaration of Independence, Thomas Jefferson’s right to life is followed by a right to liberty and a right to pursue happiness. Liberty is in the middle.

Life comes first, which makes sense. We can only be free as a Leib. No Leib, no freedom. There can be a Körper without me, but no Leib without me, as Stein said. Negative freedom makes a Körper of us, one object of many, supposedly free when other objects are not in the way. That will not do. Whatever our freedom is, it must begin from what kinds of creatures we are, involve how we differ from the world beyond, and suggest how we make contact with that world and change it.

Liberty and life are connected, if perhaps not in the way that we are usually told. It is not that we have to trade the one for the other, freedom for safety. Had I been freer when I was sick, I would also have been more secure. The absence of freedom threatens life, just as threats to life undermine freedom.

In Jefferson’s list, the pursuit of happiness comes third. Contemplating happiness teaches us important things. It is different for each of us. This can be irritating. But the implacable diversity of ideas of the good demonstrates the possibility of freedom.

Jefferson thought that happiness required virtue. His contemporary the Marquis de Sade made an unforgettable case for vice—which Jefferson’s happy life was not without.

Schopenhauer says that happiness is given, Balzac that it is made.

Bentham says that happiness can be legislated, Dostoevsky that laws displace the thing itself.

Lafargue says that idleness brings happiness, Fourier proposes labor.

Burke says that beauty promises happiness, Kawabata and Murakami (like Ovid) that it brings woe.

Leopold Staff says that we are happy when we give the most, Irène Némirovsky when we give the least.

Lammenais says that we are happy when we expect much, Goethe when we expect little.

Epictetus says that happiness returns from whence we direct our love, the Buddha teaches us to expect no such reward.

Mickiewicz says that happiness is impossible amid suffering, Tertullian that this is our chance.

Żeromski says the young are happy, Cicero the old. (According to polling data, both are right, and it is the middle decades that are the unhappiest.)

Jean-Paul Sartre defines hell as other people, his contemporary Simone Weil as loneliness.

This irresolvable disagreement about how to pursue happiness affirms a right to liberty. Happiness has to do with what we value. The things we hold dear are real, but none of us values the same things in the same way as anyone else, nor is there a single correct way to order all the virtues. There is no one good thing of which all the others are just parts or examples. If there were such a singular good, our universe would be different, and freedom would be impossible. Were humans to agree on the sources of happiness, we would be far simpler creatures, subject to programming, incapable of freedom.

On only one point do we find agreement about happiness among thinkers at all times in all cultures: health favors it. When we are well, each of us wants different things. When we are sick, we all want to get well. The Leib comes first; only with the Leib healthy can we move on to other desires and claims and values. Illness not only hinders our pursuit of happiness, it jeopardizes our lives and constrains our liberty.

HealthFreedom is about the body. The Founders knew this, but they knew little about the human organism. John Locke, an English philosopher important to American constitutional thought, treated health as an element of good government. Thomas Jefferson thought that after ethics, health was the most important thing in life. The Founders

bemoaned the epidemics that plagued their young republic, but they had no remedies. We do. George Washington inoculated his troops the best way he knew how. We know better. He died after being bled by his doctors. We wouldn't do such a thing.

The Founders held a variety of views about slavery, but even some of those who opposed its spread (such as Jefferson) owned slaves themselves. As a general matter, we can say that early American elites often did not see the body of an African as a Leib. They generally believed that people from Africa were not fully human, that their bodies were different from their own. This belief remains with us, and it makes it harder for us all to be healthy.

The racism was clear to me in the emergency room because I was dying. White people in the United States know about race, but they suppress that knowledge in an everyday covenant of ostensible ignorance. I did not learn about racism from the incident in the hospital; when I was at death's door, what I already knew surged forward to clarify the situation, because it was relevant to my own survival. Only at the extreme did I need ordinary knowledge. Black Americans cannot deny what they know, because they need it to get through the day. When white people deny what we know, we turn situations where we might all do better into situations where we all do worse. While the doctors ignored my friend, I was dying a truth I hadn't lived.

Slavery was conceived of as negative freedom: a right of the slaveowner to own property, with which the government was not to interfere. It is this tradition that leads some of us to think that government action must work against non-Black people if it is working for Black people. Negative freedom invites white people to think of themselves as self-sufficient, like plantation owners, with no need for government assistance. Then many white people (and other non-Black people) reject a right to health care since it means sharing it with Black people. This failure to recognize the Leib of the other leads to self-deception and unfreedom. In the end, one's own Leib is also ignored and abused, or even killed. We die sooner when we live a lie.

I had three problems when I was very sick: my own attitude toward my body; the commercialization of medical care; and racism. These really amount to one problem. If we do not recognize the general predicament of illness and death, if we do not recognize all bodies, then we do not recognize our own predicament when we are sick and what it means for freedom. If we conceive of liberty only as freedom from, we don't think expansively enough; we think only of ourselves, or about ourselves against the world. When we don't see the bodies of others, we don't really understand our own, and we end up giving away our own freedom and our own lives.

With respect to health, the idea of negative freedom is a dangerous relic of the past, of a time when the most that could be hoped for was property, slaves, and women to surround an ill man. We can do so much better now, and for everyone. A revolution in medicine and hygiene began after the Civil War. Physicians—and following them, governments around the world—implemented policies of hygiene, vaccination, and preventive care. These programs created not only the reality but the expectation of a much longer life.

Advances in medicine made possible a profound gain of freedom. People who are more confident about health will have greater ambitions for life. People who expect to live short lives are more likely to risk them in violence that, in turn, shortens the lives of others.

We can bring Jefferson's thought to its logical conclusion and unite his three basic rights in a fourth: the right to health care. But we will only achieve that if we manage something that the Founders did not: recognizing other bodies as equally human.

CatchingThanks to illness and inactivity, in 2020 I was clumsy. My limbs followed my directives imprecisely, and I sensed objects that were not actually there. Home from the hospital that spring, I looked for simple jobs that I could do with my body. While sweeping out the garage floor with my right arm, a catheter for antibiotics in my left, I happened across a Wiffle ball and a red plastic bat. My daughter grabbed the bat, and I put down the broom and tossed her the ball with my good hand. She hit it on the first try.

My daughter was about to turn eight. She did not even know which sport had been invoked. Teaching her to play catch as I convalesced, I had an odd feeling. Because my body had unlearned much of what it once knew, I was uncannily aware of all the motions I made to throw and receive the ball. I was more conscious of space and time, or rather of how, in its humble neuromuscular self-regulation, my body had at one time mastered them. As I got well, I slowly returned to a state that I had achieved long before by practice. I was free in that I no longer had to think about

what I was doing. Simone Weil called this habitude.

Practice does not make perfect. Nothing makes us perfect, fortunately. But practice does lead us to habitude and to grace, a quality otherwise absent from the universe. By June 2020, four months after I left the hospital, two months after the tube came out of my arm, my daughter could play catch, and so could I. The half-perceived arc of her throws sublimated into my half-aware certainty of when and where the ball would cross the plane of my body, and into the half-conscious movement that brought it unerringly into my glove. In my lack of awareness of what I was doing, I was free.

PitchingWhen I played baseball in the early 1980s, I was a pitcher. Pitching is a bit like declaring freedom. You are alone, elevated on a mound, in your little chalk circle of honor, labor, and despair. The game turns on what you do next.

On the pitcher's mound, as I came to a set before my windup, I visualized what would happen next. I imagined the pitch I was about to make—let's say a fastball up over the inside corner—and I saw, in my mind's eye, the batter hesitate and lose time judging whether it was a ball or a strike, swing late and too quickly, and miss. I even saw his grimace. In a visualization of this sort, which Stein called "an intention permeating the whole," another world appears, a beat ahead of this one. Not always, but often, I could bring the two worlds together, pitch as I wanted to, and cause the reaction I expected. In a phrase of Roger Angell's that I treasured as a kid, the baseball was my "little lump of physics."

We are neither gods nor objects. We are humans who can become sovereign. Freedom is neither the lack nor the acceptance of constraints, but rather the use of them. The mound is sixty feet and six inches from home plate, and it is elevated ten inches above the ground; that both restrains and enables a pitch. We are free to do only the things we can do, which are usually things that others taught us to do and that we practice. What a pitcher does on the mound is a result not only of choices appropriate to a game situation, but of all the repetition that came before.

The same holds for any choice we make. Just thinking about the virtues is not enough; as Aristotle said, we have to practice them by working them into the world. "Nature resists," says Simone Weil, "but it does not defend itself." You feel that resistance when you pick up a baseball or touch the strings of a guitar. The guitar strings resist the pick but yield the chord. The baseball resists as you lift it but yields as you place a middle finger on a stitch, a forefinger against the middle finger, snap your wrist, and throw a curveball. Nature gives way in beauty. When we know how to play, and that we want to play, the resistance and the yielding are the same thing.

Pitches follow rules that we did not make, and arcs that we do make. I know my throw by how my daughter receives it, and I adjust; that is knowledge I cannot attain by myself. The ball leaves my hand with my purposes attached. They are not in the first four dimensions of space and time but in a fifth, in what Edith Stein called "the world of values." Behind all my throws to my daughter are also my thoughts about how she might grow up, and in each of my throws is every throw from my own father. I do not make the world of values or the world of things, but I do sometimes make small passages between them. In this humble way, I am sovereign.

Stein wrote that the person belongs to both worlds, subject both to the "law of necessity" and to the "law of freedom." I belong to two realms, and I can stand with one foot in each. I can bring the ball through from necessity to freedom. It is still my lump of physics. My daughter is a pitcher now, too, in softball, so the lump of physics is also hers. She has chosen how to perform a task that is both very much like and very different from pitching a baseball. That decision is hers, and yet it has something to do with what she saw in me.

When we play catch, the targets are not all in the physical world. The hand that throws and the hand that catches is Leib. My daughter holds up her glove, and I can put the ball in its web, from a shorter distance or a longer one. I hold up my glove just before her throw reaches me, directed not only by her strength but also by her purpose. A little arc of aspiration trails behind the arc of a ball, like the tail of a comet.

In describing how physics treats us, Simone Weil spoke of "a double law, an evident indifference and a mysterious complicity." The universe is unaware of us, yet it sometimes plays along. The example of the thrown ball is hers.

BreathingOne day the next summer, of 2021, my daughter and I were playing catch on a running track at the edge of an old shtetl, now a Polish town near the Lithuanian border. Then we went to the main street to get ice cream. While

standing in line at the soft-serve kiosk, we saw some saxophonists taking a break in front of the (former) synagogue, the White Synagogue of Sejny.

I know, and my daughter knows, that the town's Jews were murdered after the Germans expelled them at the beginning of the Second World War. After the war, in communist Poland, the synagogue was used as a warehouse. In 1989, as communism came to an end, the building was taken over by a small troupe of actors, artists, and musicians who called themselves Borderlanders. They had a peculiar idea: that people would be freer if they could use art to see themselves, others, and the past.

The Borderlanders then began to teach local children, Poles and Lithuanians, how to play klezmer, the Jewish popular music that was widespread in Poland before the war. Day after day, year after year, local boys and girls accepted the gift of music, learning how to play instruments. Every year new kids, as young as five or six, joined the older ones. I have been listening to the orchestra play in that synagogue for longer than my daughter has been alive. I have seen the young kids become teenagers, and the teenagers become young women and men.

Each new capacity contributes to our sovereignty and so belongs to freedom. Because they can play instruments, the musicians express themselves as they would not otherwise have been able to. The music they play is Jewish, and they practice in what was once a largely Jewish town, and they perform in what was once a Jewish temple. Their breath connects them to a world of values that one day will come to them. When the moment arrives to ask what it means to have a synagogue without Jews, those Jews are not entirely absent. They are, in some way, present in the music, and the music is present in the kids—present in their bodies, in their muscles as well as in their minds.

People cry in the White Synagogue in Sejny, listening to the music. I am brought to tears when young people in the audience have the courage to dance. Much of this music was meant to be joyful, after all. Some of it is wedding music. Some of it, come to think of it, was played at my wedding.

My daughter's relatives, three or four generations earlier, were murdered in the nearest big city. The Jews of Białystok, her mother's father's people, were shot and gassed to death by the tens of thousands, having been rounded up in the local stadium. As I write this vignette, my daughter is there, in Białystok, attending the university graduation ceremony of a Polish babysitter who has become a friend.

My daughter exists only because her ancestors on her mother's father's side left Białystok, and those on her mother's mother's side left Ukraine. The first graduation ceremony she attended was in Białystok, the first wedding in Ukraine. She was a flower girl.

Sovereignty has to do with the body, with what we learn to do. It also has to do with the past, with the world we inherit. "The past and the future," says Weil, "are man's only treasures."

RecognizingWhen Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022, my daughter donated all her money to Ukrainians. During the first few weeks after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, I kept getting phone calls from American Jews, people whose ancestors had fled Ukraine, asking how they could help. They were able to recognize the injustice.

Ukraine, today the site of Putin's war of destruction and extermination, has long been an object of empires. For Stalin, it was a "fortress" of resources that were to be extracted for "internal colonization." Hitler wanted Ukraine as Lebensraum, living space. In these colonial fantasies, Ukrainians were not seen at all, or were seen as subhuman.

Leib first reverts to Körper in the mind. In Nazi propaganda, east Europeans were subhuman beasts. On Soviet posters, rich peasants were pigs. Russian television today takes this notion to a postmodern extreme: Ukrainians are to be exterminated because they are Nazis, Jews, gays, Satanists, ghouls, zombies, vermin. The next step is violence, the opposite of recognition of the Leib. When we torture or humiliate a body, we further objectify it. After the body has been degraded and the person humiliated, the killer finds the work easier to bear. Some enjoy it.

In dehumanizing others, we make ourselves unfree. If we see others only as Körper, we cannot see ourselves as Leib; we lose the promise of our own freedom. So we can only get to freedom with the help of those we might otherwise demean, mistreat, or ignore. At a rehabilitation facility in Kyiv, I watched a soldier with two prosthetic legs work out on a treadmill while practicing boxing. Another young man, who had left a safe job in another

European capital, lost his left arm and leg. He worked his right arm with a forty-kilo barbell. Talking to these men, I see myself in a different way, recognize a bit better how I reside in my body.

My own arguments about freedom would be impossible without the physical presence of others. I am writing by myself, but I am not really alone. Zelens'kyi told me that "we never really speak, others speak through us," and with these words he was making some of Edith Stein's points. We learn from people with whom we spend time, whom we respect—a word that, in its origins, means "look back, look attentively." We understand their thoughts in a different way when we have acknowledged them as people. We are more aware of our own thought processes when we think together with others. Even the books that stay with us are often given to us by people we know.

Some of the thoughts at the origins of this book arose in conversation with an admired historian friend who suffered from the neurodegenerative disorder known as Lou Gehrig's disease or ALS. By late 2008, my friend was no longer able to write in the typical sense, since he could no longer raise his hands.

I wanted him to work, so I proposed that we compose a book together on the basis of recorded conversations. I took for granted that we would have to be in the same room. Only with him could I acknowledge and challenge him. Only in the presence of the disease could we work around it. My friend felt the same way: when I called him to propose the idea, he just said, "Come over."

We worked together during the two years before his death.

My presence did work on my friend, whose name was Tony Judt, as a provocation, in a positive sense. He needed answers that were better than my questions. He wanted to remember everything that he had ever read, and he just about could. Talking to Tony, I concentrated, tapping capacities that otherwise would have lain dormant. With our phones put away, with cases of books around us, with Tony's eyes on me, I recalled citations and passages with him. Together we achieved something that would have been beyond either of us as individuals: the book that Tony titled Thinking the Twentieth Century.

AcknowledgingOne of the thinkers Tony and I found ourselves discussing was Edith Stein. She could not have written her dissertation on empathy and knowledge without the wounded soldiers. She started from the assumption, basic in philosophy since Immanuel Kant, that others were her equals, that the German men she treated were her fellow human beings.

Equal dignity is easy to grant in theory. But how do we recognize others in practice? Tending the wrecked bodies of men wounded at the front, Stein found that we acknowledge others through the Leib.

In the spring semester of 2022, ten years after Tony's and my book was published, I assigned Stein's dissertation to incarcerated students. We would read it together for the seminar in the philosophy of freedom I taught in a maximum-security prison. Though in a different way, this encounter with Stein was also inflected by illness: a pandemic. The course was supposed to have begun several weeks before it did, but prisoners and guards were sick in large numbers. I had to wait for the prison's Covid protocol to change before I could get inside. In January and February 2022, the students had their course packets and were doing the reading and did not want to wait.

I knew that I had to be in their space, at least in some limited way. That was, after all, Stein's point. Twenty years of classroom teaching had taught me the same. The students appreciated the contact, when it came, when I could enter the prison and join them in the classroom. They were quite ceremonious about the seminar; part of the ritual was that skin touched skin. Coming from different cellblocks, called over the loudspeaker by their numbers, they were happy to be bodies in the same space. Each arriving student gave the others hugs. Each one of them wanted to touch me when the class began and ended: I got white-guy handshakes.

We used the word Leib a lot. One of my incarcerated students, Dwayne, seemed captivated by Stein and summarized her arguments beautifully. You "have to see the body of others to see your own body," and so objectivity "is not being yourself without distractions, it is recognizing the other body as being like your body, and then seeing the world." "When I am imprisoned in my own self," wrote Stein, "I can never get beyond the world as it appears to me." But "thanks to empathy I get repeated appearances of that same world that are independent of my perception." It is empathy that allows us to know that the external world is real.

Empathy, in other words, is not a condescending concession of a rational person to the emotions of others, but the only way to become a reasonable person. To acknowledge the corporeality of others is not a gift to them but a step toward our own reason. “The constitution of the foreign individual,” wrote Stein in her dissertation, “was a condition for the full constitution of our own individuality.” The bodies of others allow us to see them as subjects, as in the same predicament as we are. Empowered then by empathy, we can see ourselves as others see us. That helps us both to know ourselves and to know the world. That knowledge, in turn, makes us better subjects, more sovereign.

We have to see the bodies of others as subjects, because otherwise we cannot see ourselves as subjects. And if we fail to do that, we cannot be free.

SeeingIn Ukraine, meanwhile, other bodies I knew, friends or colleagues or students, were in trenches or bomb shelters or in flight from the Russian invasion. At the time of that first class in prison, March 2022, Ukrainian friends with families were trying to find a way to flee Kyiv. My incarcerated students wanted to hear about the war. I was not supposed to turn my back on them, but I did so the first day to draw battle maps on the whiteboard.

We imagined a disaster thousands of miles away, in a country that none of my students had visited, and that to them at first was all but unknown. The application of what we were discussing, though, was clear enough. If Russian invaders believed that Ukrainians were less than human, then raping women and executing men was no crime: Ukrainian bodies were objects to begin with. In acting this way, of course, the Russians opened the logical possibility that they, too, were simply objects: to be sent somewhere to die pointlessly on the basis of lies. If we do not recognize one another through the Leib, we not only cause suffering to others but bring unfreedom to ourselves.

What if I think that my body is something more than a Körper, but no one else agrees? Then (my students pointed out) others can attach and detach meanings to me as they will, and my own values will never make their way out into the world. I can be enslaved, tortured, segregated. If I do not exist as a Leib because the existence of my group is denied, I can be subjected to genocide.

The students appreciated Stein’s contention about the Leib but wondered how far she would have taken it. After all, the soldiers she treated in the First World War were her fellow Germans—or fellow white people, as my students saw it. Most of my students were Black, and all of them expressed this suspicion.

Meeting during the first four months after Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine, my students came to see that Europeans can colonize other Europeans—that is, that white people can colonize other white people. Their realization calls into question the universality of the American notion of “white people”—or, when construed positively, provides an example of empathy.

The students extended their literary and philosophical references to Ukraine and applied their personal experiences to those of Ukrainians. My student Alpha expressed solidarity in the highest degree when he said, “The suffering of Ukrainians affects me as a Black man.” By the end of the class, Alpha said that he admired Ukraine’s president Volodymyr Zelens’kyi as an anti-colonialist.

In their querying of Stein, the students were onto something, though I resisted them at the time. Stein was certainly a German nationalist when she wrote about empathy in 1917. She considered it “out of the question that we will now be defeated.” She was probably not thinking critically then about the German war aim of conquering Ukraine and treating it as a breadbasket. In her field hospital, though, she was treating soldiers of the multinational Habsburg army as well as German soldiers. Ukraine did not exist at the time, and its lands were divided between Russia and the Habsburg monarchy. So young Ukrainian men were fighting on both sides. Confronted with their wounded bodies, Stein empathized with their predicament.

Would she have empathized with Black men? That’s where the students had their doubts. For their part, though, they were able to imagine her position and to empathize both with her and with Ukrainians past and present. One student, Michael, was aware of another moment when Ukraine was treated colonially: the political famine in Soviet Ukraine. After the First World War, the Bolshevik Revolution, and a series of other wars, most of what is now Ukraine was incorporated by the Soviet Union. Joseph Stalin saw Ukraine as a territory to be tamed and exploited. As a result of the collectivization of agriculture, millions of Ukrainians were brought to the verge of starvation. Stalin then took a series of decisions in late 1932 that ensured that about four million people in Soviet Ukraine in fact died. Michael

knew a poignant detail: that Ukrainians during Stalin's starvation campaign referred to Harriet Beecher Stowe's novel Uncle Tom's Cabin. Having once cried for the slaves in the book, Ukrainians now identified with them. In one of his papers, Michael mentioned his own aged mother, whose African American son was in prison and had been for thirty years. In early 2022, Michael told me, she watched the news about Ukraine and cried. She could see.

The world in which Russia invades and tortures and America impoverishes and humiliates is one world, and it can be understood, especially when people are physically present. My incarcerated students learned the names of Ukrainian writers. When I took this manuscript to Ukrainian colleagues in Ukraine, they learned the names of my incarcerated students. There was something pleasing about conservative Ukrainian humanists sitting around a table in Lviv discussing the views of Alpha, a radical young African American thousands of miles away. They could see him. Thanks to everyone who was discussing the book, whether they were in an American prison or in a Ukrainian city mourning its dead, I gained a broader view.

Russia has become a genocidal fascist empire for many reasons, but one of them is negative freedom. This concept made it hard to see that its oligarchy was the antithesis of freedom (rather than a side effect) or that Putin was a fascist (rather than just a technocrat seeking wealth). And America has become a flawed republic threatened by oligarchy and fascism for many reasons, but negative freedom is among them. It leads us to think that we have solved our problems when we have privatized them, when in fact all we have achieved is separating ourselves from one another.

SwimmingMy country is also my incarcerated students' country. They had done what they had done, and I have done what I have done, but there is a larger logic behind my being at Yale and their being in prison. The land that celebrated its bicentennial in 1976 was on the way to locking up more of its citizens than any other, as a matter of racial policy. That I was only about one-fifth as likely to go to prison as a Black person was due to no merit of my own.

One June day in 1976, a few weeks before I rang that bell, I was sitting in a yellow school bus, alone on a bench seat near the back. It was the last week of first grade, and I was looking at the elementary school yearbook.

It was a simple stapled affair, with a two-color cardboard cover, one glossy page for each class, black-and-white photographs in rows and columns, the teacher at the top left. In her picture, my teacher sported a tremendous Afro, thick round glasses, and a turtleneck sweater beneath a plaid overall dress of the sort she favored. A third-grader peering over my shoulder mocked me for the race of my teacher, calling out the standard term of abuse. It was the first time I had ever heard the word. I didn't know what it meant, but I had a notion, since I knew the kid and his attitudes.

The bus route took us past the local swim club. As a boy, I wondered why it was a "club." I took lessons and spent pleasant summer afternoons there with my brothers. Driving there in my father's tiny convertible, top down, was an unforgettable pleasure. When I got older, I found it annoying to carry the membership card, especially since I was always losing things. It seemed strange to me that kids would brag about the different kinds of privileges afforded by the different colors of their card. A bored teenager checked the laminated credentials at the entrance.

It was a nice place. Perhaps no one had any bad intentions. And yet the swim club reflected an unmistakable national reality. Our subdevelopment was built after Supreme Court rulings and the 1964 Civil Rights Act made it illegal for cities to exclude African Americans from public swimming pools. Around the country, municipalities then filled in their public pools with cement. Public goods like swimming pools passed to the private sector, where membership rules could informally enforce prejudice. This was a minor element of a larger political reaction to the Civil Rights Act.

When we choose not to recognize other bodies as human, we create specific social situations, which we then define as the state of nature. Having been excluded from swimming pools, Black kids were less likely to learn to swim than white kids. And so white kids were instructed that Black bodies were not buoyant. This was "common knowledge."

There were at most one or two Black kids at the pool that summer of 1976, maybe none. There were certainly no Black kids on the bus that day. A social arrangement, the creation of zoned suburban neighborhoods, was keeping certain bodies apart.

In a space without Black people, the point of yelling a racial slur was to create a group: everyone against the absent teacher and against anyone who defended the absent teacher. If we use language to treat others' bodies as objects of one color, we define ourselves as objects of another. We enter into a mindless physical collectivity, a racial mob. We sacrifice our own Leib to the cause of denying the Leib of another.

School might help, but we have to be taught to acknowledge the Leib of the other. I was lucky in that I was challenged at home and saw African Americans in settings chosen by my family. But I do not remember being challenged at school. What we learned about Jim Crow was that it had come to an end. We should have known that Jim Crow inspired German racial laws, which made Jews (such as Edith Stein) second-class citizens. Along with the laws came initiatives from below, such as banning Jews from swimming pools.

It might seem like a small thing, but no one ever taught me about the swimming pools.

ContractFreedom begins with sovereignty, and sovereignty has to do with bodies. And so the philosophy of freedom begins with a baby's cry. Babies pull us to the philosophical issues that are so basic that they escape attention. I began to see the world differently when I cut my son's umbilical cord.

We are all born into a blurry storm of circumstance. This is an experience we all share, though none of us recalls it. We know about birth and can consider it only thanks to others. Recalling that we all begin with a shriek can deliver us from philosophical errors that stand behind American oppression.

In American culture, birth is surrounded by taboos. The silence around the most significant moment in life shields our prevailing notion of negative freedom from some basic critiques. Birth reveals its absurdity. A newborn is not going to become free thanks to the absence of something. You can summon others to a journey toward freedom with a beautiful declaration, but you cannot abandon a baby at the foot of a mountain with a benediction of liberty.

A negative idea of freedom seems plausible when we begin our thought process from an idealized image of adults and forget the bodily predicament that we all shared as newborns. If we begin from magical maturity, we can assume that freedom is only a matter of defending what we already have, of what already exists. Defining freedom only as something that can be lost, we never ask how it was gained, how people become sovereign in the first place.

Sovereignty usually means the sovereignty of the state, its capacity to dominate or at least to set the terms of life. But if we regard freedom positively, we can think of sovereignty differently, as being about the person rather than the state. We then take the first step toward a better justification for government.

How did we come to think of a government as sovereign? To imagine a situation in which citizens have some sort of standing or rights, we treat sovereignty as inhering in political institutions. The notion, in traditions such as ours, is that at some point there was a social contract, in which people—idealized adults, of course—met and agreed to form a government. The problem with this move is that such a thing never happened.

The American case comes about as close as can be: people met and agreed upon the Constitution. But the men who wrote that document can hardly be thought to be representative of everyone. Even had they been perfectly representative of the wealthy white landowner class, the exclusion of the non-landed, the African Americans, the women, and the Native Americans means that their covenant can hardly stand on its own in modern times. And why exactly should newborns be subject to an ancient order that they could not possibly have chosen? How is that freedom?

Fascists pointed out the problems with this tradition of sovereignty. The most intelligent of them, the legal theorist Carl Schmitt, argued that true sovereignty resided not in following the rules, as laid down by the contract, but in making an exception to them. Whoever could make the exception was the true sovereign. An Adolf Hitler taking advantage of a Reichstag Fire to declare a state of exception was thus an ideal sovereign.

Schmitt's view, though, was nothing more than cleverness. Rule breaking, though it appeals to the emotions, cannot be sovereignty. Negating an illusion does not generate substance. To say that he who makes an exception is sovereign is at most a statement of fact about power, leaving entirely open what sovereignty means or ought to mean. The fascist notion of sovereignty is puerile, a boyish joke. We need to begin not with overgrown boys but with actual children.

The fascist solution is incompatible with freedom, but the fascist critique of the social contract does reveal a problem. If we expect people to accept the institutions into which they were born, on the basis of an agreement that is largely (or totally) fictional, how can that be generative of freedom? A constitution must not only constitute but reconstitute, over and over again. This can be done.

The solution is to relocate the idea of sovereignty in the person. Freedom is the value of values, because it is the condition in which all other values may be exercised. A government is not legitimate just because it has power and uses the word sovereign to embellish decrepitude and deception. It is legitimate insofar as it enables freedom, enacting policies that allow young and coming generations to become sovereign.

A person has a beginning, and that is the opportunity. To enable freedom, a government must begin at that beginning, with birth and with youth. Practically, this is indispensable to freedom; ethically, it is indispensable to legitimacy, since freedom is the value of values. Governments do not produce children, but a good government can make child-rearing more likely to ease the way to a life in freedom.

A government that does not claim to be sovereign, but that aims for the sovereignty of its children, legitimizes itself by its work for freedom. And it does so with respect not to a myth of the past or to people who are dead but with respect to each coming generation and to people who are coming to life.

ContactIn thinking about freedom, we tend to leave out the time between birth and maturity, the formative period of life. The first form of freedom, sovereignty, is blocked out. We have no chance to consider what a baby's body is, what efforts and policies that Leib will need.

A baby will need nourishment, shelter, and warmth. A baby will need other people, an upbringing, an education. The Roman historian Livy defined freedom as "standing upright oneself without depending on another's will." At some point in the logic of life, this definition is true—but not while we are in the womb or at the nipple, unable physically to stand upright. When we are very young, we all need someone else's goodwill if we are to learn to stand at all. Because we live in time in a certain direction, we cannot make up later for what we were not given earlier.

We are born undeveloped compared to other mammals. Our large heads (for our large brains) require us to leave the womb early, before we are capable of much of anything. Yet with time and attention, especially in the first months and years, those large brains can become capable minds.

Humans evolved to be patient and evaluative, as hunters, gatherers, nomads, and farmers, and as parents, siblings, cousins, and grandparents of children who need years of attention. Patience and evaluation continue to serve us in our modern world. But such capacities arise only if young people make contact with people around them. The creation of individuality must be a social act.

Just bearing a child does not bring the knowledge that mothers (or parents or a family) need, nor the time needed to apply it. Babies are thrown into a world that, if governed by negative freedom, must be senseless and grotesque. They cannot be raised by the absence of barriers. They need things they cannot themselves know. No infant can liberate its parents, or give them time, or set policy. Freedom works as a larger cooperative project, over generations, or not at all.

Those who care about childhood should care about freedom, and those who care about freedom should care about children. This means caring about the society into which the next American baby will be born. Individual freedom is a social project and a generational one. For people to grow up in freedom, the right structures must already be in place when they are born.

And so not just the philosophy but the work of freedom begins with birth. We labor, though, under a tradition of philosophy that looks away from life's most fundamental moment. The existentialists and their teacher Martin Heidegger thought that our problem was that we ignore death. That conclusion, meant to be grim and bare and masculine, actually skirts the issue, as Edith Stein pointed out. The real problem is that we ignore life.

My wife, Marci Shore, who is writing a book about the larger tradition of which Heidegger and the existentialists were part (phenomenology), was deep into it during her pregnancy. When she was in labor, a nurse complimented her on her German. She answered, in German, gasping, "I am good on obstetrics and phenomenology." Heidegger

has the idea of “being toward death.” I (later) told Marci that she should write a pregnancy memoir called “being toward life.”

“Beginning, before it becomes a historical event, is the supreme capacity of man,” says Hannah Arendt. “Politically, it is identical with man’s freedom.” Sovereignty begins with birth and arises as a child is held, loved, reared, and educated. For the universe, a human birth is nothing special; for us humans, natality is the possibility of a life in freedom. We close that potential when we limit freedom to avoiding other objects, or begin our philosophy with death rather than life.

LoanEdith Stein was the youngest of eleven children. Her father died when she was young. Four of her siblings died before she was born. Growing up in these conditions, she understood that the “creation of capabilities belongs to freedom.”

Reading Stein in prison, my students seized on the point that children need to spend time with adults to become sovereign. As children, they themselves had wanted attention from adults that they could not get. The research is on their side: negative childhood experiences correlate strongly with adversity in later life.

Simone Weil wrote that “the one thing that man possesses that is essentially individual, that is absolutely his own, is his capacity to think.” And yet in the million years our species has trod the earth, this “essentially individual” capacity has never been developed individually. Babies who are left alone learn nothing. This is, sadly, not just a hypothesis. Historians have all too much confirmatory evidence—from the Gulag, for example, or from the orphanages of communist Romania.

Our knowledge of early childhood development can enable sovereignty. We know that the Leib gains most of its capacities during the first five years of life, as the brain grows to nearly full size. And we know that the process is social. The brains of infants are primed for contact, but infants cannot make contact by themselves. Neural pathways emerge when babies are physically touched. Babies are good at recognizing faces when they are held so that they can see them. Their throats, tongues, and lips are capable of forming words, but do so only when they can imitate someone else’s speech.

Putting alternatives in front of very young children is easy. Teaching them to evaluate and choose is harder. It takes caring people who have the time to care. Choice is a reality outside but also a capability inside. We need the ability to see alternatives as well as the external capacity to realize them. An American way to make people unfree is to wax on about choice but deny children the capacities they will need to make choices (or to realize that they have been denied them). The richer our capacities, the more alternatives we see, and the more choices we can make.

How many alternatives present themselves to us has to do with how we feel. Positive emotions broaden the range of choices we see and extend our experience of time. Negative emotions limit that range to immediate fight or flight. Fear is like that, limiting us to the binary. It turns our minds into circuits, our bodies into objects: Leib recedes into Körper.

With help, small children learn to name and regulate their emotions. Fear is sometimes appropriate, but knowing it and naming it are steps toward controlling it—and toward preventing others from manipulating it. Regulating emotions is a step toward the evaluation that enables freedom. If we are nothing more than our first reactions, we are prey to the people who arouse those reactions. Only individuals can resist pressure from others, yet it takes others to create such individuals. We can learn to govern ourselves only with the right kind of guidance, at the right stage of life.

Abundant research indicates what helps small children to gain these basic capacities: constant physical and vocal contact; trusting relationships; unstructured play; and choices about things and people. The attributes we need to be free individuals are available to us only through coordinated action. Babies can be raised and educated to become free, but babies cannot create for themselves the setting where this is possible. Since freedom requires capacities that we cannot develop by ourselves, we owe our freedom to others. Every free adult had manifold help as a child.

When we think of jobs that are associated with freedom, the first that comes to mind might be pilot or cowboy. Motherhood belongs to freedom. As the Ed and Patsy Bruce song reminds us, all those cowboys had mamas. The occupations that are most relevant to freedom are the caregivers: the elementary school teachers, the preschool

teachers, the childcare workers. A society concerned with freedom would respect such people and pay them well.

Freedom requires capacity, capacity requires attention in childhood, and attention requires time. It follows that parents' time, the mothers' above all, belongs to freedom. Adults lend to children a special kind of time, one that children cannot give adults, one that children cannot give children, one that adults cannot give adults.

Simone Weil said that everything precious in us comes from others, not as a gift but as "a loan that must be constantly renewed." Children borrow from adults a special kind of time. They can repay the loan only much later, when they are adults, by giving time to someone of the next generation. Government serves as a kind of guarantor of the loan, creating the conditions in which those who raise children can have time. A land of the free pays it back and pays it forward.

In leaving out birth from the account of freedom, we also make it impossible to accommodate the Leib of women. Because women can be impregnated by rapists, the orientation of their Leib has to be different from that of men. In previous understandings of freedom, this issue did not arise, since it was assumed that women and slaves served the freedom of a powerful few.

Treating freedom solely as the absence of barriers gives us no instruction about rape. An idea of negative freedom as freedom from violence can seem to help here. It understates the stakes, though: it is not just that we have the right not to be raped, but that we should be able to live lives without the trauma or anticipation of rape. What people can become is limited by both the prospect and the memory of rape, and we can fully grasp this idea only when we take the bodies of others seriously.

Acknowledging the Leib of women also means understanding that they think about childbirth in a way that men generally do not. Women have to decide whether and when to have children, and they have to adjust other parts of their lives. Negative freedom leaves them to make those adjustments alone. If we make accommodations for childbirth, we remove a source of unfreedom for women and improve the chances that children can grow up free.

OpeningDeath is simple and tempting. Fascism beguiles us with meaning drawn from the death of others and from our own. It is much easier to philosophize when we ignore what is most alive about us, when we fail to confront what Weil called the mystery of our bodies.

The death principle crept into philosophy early, in Plato's cave. Plato's conviction was that the things we experience in this world are not fully real but are rather imperfect copies of some ideal version of each thing. And so each bell, for example, is somehow just an emanation of a perfect bell that exists somewhere else, as is each tree or each bed in each maternity ward. We live under the illusion, Plato thought, that these things are fully real; it is the task of philosophy, he taught, to deliver us from this mistake. For this purpose, he provided (in his Republic) the memorable allegory of the cave.

Imagine that people are in chains, deep in a dark cavern, and can only look forward, at one cave wall. Behind them is a fire, and between them and the fire, people walk back and forth behind a wall, holding up a succession of "carved objects." All the enchained people can see are shadows cast on the wall before them. This, says Plato, is what our existence is like. We are shackled in a cave, gazing at a play of shadows, believing that we are in reality. We must think our way out, to a world where each thing exists in an ideal form.

This is a very evocative notion, and of course it cannot be proven false. Its plausibility, though, depends on ignoring basic experiences of life.

If you watch a childbirth, it is hard to think: This is a shallow, partial replica of something else, only a reflection of some ideal birth taking place on an ideal plane. When my wife experienced complications after the birth of our son, I did not think: This blood is not actual blood and this red is not actual red but just a hint of what blood and red might be. When the nurses left our newborn son with me while doctors sprinted from another wing of the hospital to operate on her, I did not think that the violet of his eyes was nothing more than an emanation of some ideal violet or eye, nor that the sound of the rushed footfalls in the hall was anything other than the only reality. And what is true of birth is true of the moment after birth and of all the moments thereafter. There is no cave, except the one we enter when we close our eyes to the world and our hearts to others.

There are indeed ideals, but they are not ideal bells or beds. They are virtues, notions of how the world might be different from and better than it is. As sovereign individuals, we learn to care about these ideals, and balance them, and bring them to life. We can also learn to create them. We don't borrow from an ideal world. We reach toward it and expand it.

If we think, though, that the world we experience is not the real world but is only a cave or (as people say now) a computer simulation, then we might conclude that such activity makes no sense. If we believe that life is elsewhere, then freedom is senseless, since we have no power to exist on that other plane, let alone to change it. Our only chance at freedom would seem to be to reach that elsewhere by shedding our imperfect bodies by dying (or as people imagine now, becoming one's own digital avatar).

This is the primal form of negative freedom: we can be free only by removing a barrier, and that barrier is our own bodies. We reject Leib and seek Körper. We embrace the death principle.

This conclusion haunts Plato's argument. In the Republic, Plato has Socrates, his teacher, describe the cave. Socrates is the archetype of the lonely philosopher, whose truths are beyond this world. After Socrates is sentenced to death, he calls the separation from his body a "release," a liberation. This cannot be right. Our body is not just one Körper among others, blocking some other life that is elsewhere and preventing us from reaching that higher state. Our Leib is special in that it touches both the realm of what is and the realm of what should be.

The allegory of the cave, properly understood, makes this case. As told by Plato, it wrongly conveys what people would experience. It makes no corporeal sense. Socrates says that "such captives," the people bound in the cave, "would consider the truth to be nothing but the shadows of the carved objects." No, they would not. Socrates ignores the bodies of the shackled people. If people were in fact shackled in a cave, their first reality would be their own bodily suffering, the iron on their flesh, not the shadows on a wall. When they noticed the shadows, the ones to which the shackled people would attend first would be their own. The shadows they would actually see on the wall, most consistently and most intelligibly, would be those of their own bodies.

The shackled people would have the truth of their own suffering. Within seconds, they would also apprehend the connection between certain shadows and their own bodies. Before long, they would also understand that they were not alone. They would see the shadows of other bodies and identify them as such. Even were they somehow chained so that they could not turn their heads to see the other people's bodies, they would quickly apprehend that the shadows on the wall that were similar to their own led back to other bodies, other people. They would understand that those others must be in a similar predicament, sharing a similar experience. And as they understood others, they would better understand themselves. This is what would actually happen in Plato's cave. The shadows of the "carved objects" would seem dubious and artificial, and rightly so.

So the cave allegory, if we do the optics correctly, leads to an entirely different conclusion from the one proposed by Plato and accepted by tradition. As a thought experiment, it actually shows that knowledge begins with the body, and that understanding begins from recognizing the presence of other bodies. The story of the cave, which is the story of Western philosophy, developed the way it did only because the body was written out of existence.

And so a correction must be made. Plato knew Socrates as a highly individuated adult, someone who was indifferent not only to prevailing opinions but to his own body and its pains and pleasures. No doubt Socrates was an admirably free person. He risked death for what he believed. But it is his capacity for freedom, rather than what he said about freedom, that interests us. Freedom is not about being right, which is elusive, but about trying to do right. How did Socrates come to be free? The answer cannot really begin from his thinking, right or wrong as it might have been. It has to begin with his life.

Socrates himself gives us a hint. Like all of us, Socrates had a mother. He spoke of her in one of his philosophical inquiries, comparing his own work as a philosopher to hers as a midwife. Toward the end of his life, Plato tells us, Socrates compared philosophy to childbirth, and thoughts to children.

His mother's name, Phaenarete, means "realizes virtue," a touching promise. We cannot realize virtue on our own, but we can learn to do so with the help of midwives and mothers and other people. Socrates, wrong as he was on other matters, rightly said that none of us is self-sufficient. Children need help from mothers, mothers need help from midwives, everyone at the beginning of life needs the help of others.

Natality, not fatality. Better a womb than a tomb. Thinking of Socrates's mother, we begin the philosophy of freedom not from an enclosing cave but from an opening world.

UnpredictabilityImprobable StatesMy world opened up through reading, a capability I owed to others. People brought me to books, and books brought me to people. As I came of age, I was fascinated by the Czech dissident Václav Havel and his account of freedom, so different from the one I had imbibed in school or from movies. I was reading Havel in 1989 as communism came to an end in his native Czechoslovakia and throughout eastern Europe. The texts that captivated me arose when I was a child, in 1975 and 1978, around the time that I was ringing that bell and first thinking about freedom.

Havel started as a poet and ended as a president, with time as a playwright and a prisoner in between. Born in an interwar Czechoslovakia that was still democratic and independent, he was a small child when Nazi Germany dismembered his country in 1938, and a boy of twelve when communists took it over in 1948. Havel was fortunate in the care taken with his education, despite the circumstances. During the Prague Spring of 1968, a brief moment when Czechoslovak communists permitted freedom of assembly and of speech, Havel spoke up for multiparty elections.

After the Soviet Union (and its Warsaw Pact allies) invaded Czechoslovakia that August, Havel was blacklisted and could no longer legally publish his plays. He moved from Prague to the countryside and eventually took a job at a brewery. In 1975 he wrote a two-character play "about" the experience, to be performed among friends. Audience is set in a police state occupied by its superpower neighbor, both of which are ruled by communist parties notionally following Marxism. Yet the play has no ideology and no soldiers, and only a single policeman, who is present only in conversation.

The play is about what we do to each other within such structures. In Audience, a dissident employed by a brewery is summoned to meet the brewmaster. The brewmaster must, of course, inform on his politically suspect employee. From frothily roundabout conversations, it emerges that the brewmaster is friendly with the secret police officer to whom he submits the reports. The brewmaster wants to help his policeman friend, but he could use some assistance himself. He is not a good writer, and reasons that time could be saved all around if the dissident wrote the reports on himself, the brewmaster signed them, and the secret policeman filed them. The dissident eventually accedes to this.

In this brilliant bit of theater, Havel captured something of the Czechoslovakia of the 1970s. This was the period known as "normalization." No one believed in Marxism. Many Czechs and Slovaks did as late as 1968, during "the Prague Spring" that allowed free expression and promised reform. After Soviet tanks crushed the Prague Spring that August, the idea of socialism remained as excuse rather than as aspiration. The system was present everywhere not so much as ideology but as conformity; the temptation was simply to let it function. To be sure, it was easier when the dissident reported on himself. Yet doing so was to give up on dignity; as the dissident and the brewmaster agreed afterward, "Everything is shit." Cynicism about the system slips into nihilism that serves the system.

It might seem harmless to concede that there are no virtues, nothing to value in life. It might even seem to be consistent with freedom: If nothing is true, then surely everything is permitted? On this basis, we would oppose barriers to our impulses—but we would lack an argument against the powerful whose impulse is to control us. If we accept that "everything is shit," if nothing is any better than anything else, we have no basis for sovereign choices, and gain no practice in the building of a self. We will mutter under our breath and accept our place in a system.

In 1975 Havel also wrote an open letter to Gustav Husák, the leader of the Czechoslovak communist party, about "the gradual erosion of all moral standards." Havel was a Bohemian in every sense; by "moral standards" he did not mean buttoned-up self-righteousness. He meant freedom, beginning with an affirmation of humanity. Only on that terrain do meaningful choices exist. Without a sense of what should be, we cannot be clear about how what is could ever change. In communist Poland, Adam Michnik, another dissident, read Havel's open letter and was impressed. A meeting was planned. It was delayed by Havel's arrest and imprisonment in 1977, but the next year it took place.

On a sunny day in August 1978, Havel eluded the secret police, made for the Czechoslovak-Polish border, and hiked to the top of a mountain. There he and other Czechoslovak dissidents met Michnik and other Polish ones. They built a fire, ate, and drank vodka. In the photographs, they look happy. Michnik asked Havel to write. Three months later, an underground courier delivered Havel's manuscript to Michnik in Warsaw. From a moment of contact at a border on a mountaintop arose Havel's essay "The Power of the Powerless," a profound meditation on freedom.

In the essay, Havel translated the experience of “normalized” Czechoslovakia into general political lessons. “Normalization” meant adaptation to the party line, even though no one believed it expressed anything beyond the convenience of the powerful. Normality in this sense of “normalization” has no substance, only form. It is the habit of saying (and then thinking) what seems necessary, while agreeing implicitly (and then explicitly) that nothing really matters. Life becomes an echo chamber of all the things we never dare to say.

The pretending was what Havel called “unfreedom,” the concession of the authentic self. All the authorities needed was for people to react to stimuli: positively to consumer goods, negatively to the threat of prison. Modern tyranny, Havel concluded, required not devotion but predictability. Normalization forced life into “the most probable states.”

Declarations and AccommodationsI loved this text in 1989, and still teach it decades later, because it helped me to see how “normal” could mean two different things. If what is normal is what everyone else does, then conformism can collapse to a single, meaningless, dark point. But if normal is what one should do, then an aperture opens instead, into a realm of dreams, aspirations, and judgments. If Havel is right, and unfreedom means predictability, then freedom must involve unpredictability. It is the second form of freedom, arising from sovereignty, or what Havel called “autonomy.”

Sovereignty (or autonomy) takes work. Havel did not dwell on this, having been raised in a prosperous family and having had an excellent education. We need support to become autonomous people, sovereign individuals. Freedom requires a positive presence, not a malign neglect. Youth is a chance for freedom that must not be wasted. By the time brain functions are complete, at the age of about twenty, sovereign young people can show the world their unpredictability.

Havel was concerned with the power of the state to make us predictable. But what is such a state working against? How does our human unpredictability arise? The choices of each sovereign person will be in a unique combination, grounded in a unique set of commitments. But uniqueness at a given moment is only the beginning of unpredictability. No choice is ever final, not just because the world changes around us, but because different values will suggest themselves to us at different points.

A sovereign person, in making choices, is acting not only within the physical world, but in a realm of good and evil, right and wrong, virtue and vice. That zone, which Stein called “the world of values,” is not an extension of the world of things. It is a kind of fifth dimension, with its own rules, and as such a reservoir of unpredictability for our own world of four dimensions, of space and time. The virtues do not interact with one another, or with objects, as objects do with other objects.

The fifth dimension, so to speak, has its own physics, its own geometry. When we make choices and affirm values, that different geometry of the fifth dimension seeps into our world, making us and it less predictable.

The values cannot be judged in the same terms as physical objects: we can say that a thing is bigger than another thing, but we cannot say that loyalty is bigger than honesty. Another difference: choosing between values is an act of affirmation, not of consumption. When we choose beauty, there is more beauty, not less. We leave behind the unchosen thing, whereas the unchosen value always awaits us. We might affirm it later, or even find some way to combine it with other values. As we move forward in time, we not only leave a trace of our choices behind us but also accumulate a new capacity for combining values within us.

Meanwhile, every sovereign person is doing the same thing. Everyone we encounter is facing an unceasing succession of choices in their own arrangements of unique circumstances, applying their own combinations of values. When people are sovereign together, they generate unpredictability. As they do so, they recognize this in one another, welcome it, and gain from it. When we apprehend others as Leib, we see them doing what we are doing, making choices in the zone between the world of things and the world of values.

Working together, people bring human unpredictability into the world, and joyfully. This helps us to be free of all the people and forces who would rule us by predicting us or by making us more predictable. Free people are predictable to themselves but unpredictable to authorities and machines. Unfree people are unpredictable to themselves and predictable to rulers.

Such unpredictability allows us to become our individual selves, together. The texture of the world of values enters

our own world.

Entropy and GravityHavel strained toward that world of values, that fifth dimension, which he called “moral standards.” Yet he also had in mind the physical world, the first four dimensions, the restraints we need for creativity.

Havel was preoccupied with the Second Law of Thermodynamics, according to which disorder, quantified by entropy, grows over time. “Moral standards” meant a limitation of chaos by ethics. “Just as the constant increase in entropy is the basic law of the universe,” he wrote to Husák, “so it is the basic law of life to be ever more highly structured and to struggle against entropy.” Normalization, by contrast, was a politics of entropy, a decomposition. Life was pre-death.

The freedom that Havel had in mind was a “life principle,” resistance to a deadening politics of predictability. When we have access to ideas of the good, of virtue, we bring something fresh to the universe: “Life rebels against all uniformity and leveling; its aim is not sameness, but variety, the restlessness of transcendence, the adventure of novelty and rebellion against the status quo.” A single improbable act “illuminates its surroundings” and makes possible other such acts.

Like Simone Weil, Havel was seeking a descriptive transcendence, a language that respected the truths of the physical world, including the truth that we can get beyond it. Whereas Weil had a brother, André, who was a renowned mathematician, Havel’s brother, Ivan, was a noted cyberneticist. Where Weil wrote in the 1940s of a “law of freedom” and a “law of necessity,” Havel wrote in the 1970s about “the law of life” and “the most probable states.” Where she said “gravity,” he preferred “entropy.”

We cannot be neutral: we either deaden the world around us, or we make it more lively. Both Weil and Havel were convinced that we can be manipulated into making the physical world more predictable. Yet we can also make it less predictable, by finding passages to the improbable realm of “freedom” or “life.” We learn about our Körper and the physical world to reach its edges, to better understand our own Leib and extend our chances. We need knowledge of both what is and what should be to experience that “restlessness of transcendence”—a phrase of Havel’s that sounds very much like Weil.

Our MachinesUnlike Weil (1909–43), Havel (1936–2011) lived to see a world of screens. In the 1970s, the Czechoslovak communist party shifted to television as the primary means of political instruction. The aim was not to persuade people of the truth of Marxism but to induce them to see the present order as the only possible one. Communists on television dramas were portrayed not as engineers of a bright future but as regular guys doing their jobs, which just happened to be collectivizing agriculture or knocking down historic town squares. Violence hovered in the background of the entertainment, in the form of the recent Soviet invasion and in the certainty of prison for any overt resistance.

Communists had ruled by open violence: terror in the 1950s, invasion in the 1960s. As Weil wrote, and as Havel and other Czechoslovak dissidents said, violence against our bodies is meant to make the victim a predictable object—and it has a similar effect on the perpetrator. And yet, as the novelist Aldous Huxley prophesied, tyranny can be based less on “hitting” than on “sitting”—or really, on the alternation between them: lash, then leash. In the 1970s, the violence was never forgotten, but it was blurred by pleasure. Czechoslovak television could engineer a situation in which trams were empty because everyone was watching the same serial, in which conversations about plot displaced conversations about life. Those in power could use technology to make people more homogenous and less threatening to power.

Donna Haraway cautioned in 1985 that “our machines are disturbingly lively, and we ourselves are frighteningly inert.” Like Havel, she was writing in the age of television, before the arrival of the internet. Social media today are far livelier than television. In our century, inertness is a feature, not a bug. Some people, of course, can nimbly exploit the internet to convey their personality and achieve their ends. The machine is built, though, to manufacture probability. Our screens seek our most probable states, refine them, and reinforce them. Algorithms herd us into categories defined by our least interesting features and distract us from the choices to be made in the physical and social world around us. Social media make us more predictable than we need to be and so easier to rule. Havel anticipated just such a digital future. He called computerized predictability an example of the “death principle.”

Normalization in Czechoslovakia followed the end of faith in Marxism in 1968, the collapse of a certain view that technological change must bring human freedom. Like the Czechoslovak communists, the Silicon Valley libertarians first promised a brave new world, then told us that there were no alternatives, then invited us to live inside a screen. Like the communists, they passed from great certainty about utopia to total nihilism about everything, to a world in which "everything is shit."

And then they ask us if we are not, perhaps, living in a computer simulation ourselves—or, in an older language, inside Plato's cave. Unfortunately, wealthy and important people who speak of simulations are searching for an excuse to be irresponsible. If we decide that we are not real, that life is elsewhere, we can drop into a cave where morality has no sense and freedom is impossible.

Our CosmonautsIn 1976, America's bicentennial year, communist Czechoslovakia was at the height of official conformism and consumerism. The communists suppressed alternative culture, including rock and roll music, on the correct suspicion that it brought new values. The secret police had been surveilling rock musicians. That March, it arrested nineteen people from the underground scene, including members of a band called the Plastic People of the Universe as well as some other individual performers and members of other bands. This got Havel's attention. Blacklisted himself as an artist, he came to think that rock musicians embodied the "hidden life of society" that he had described the year before in his open letter to Husák.

When contemplating the art of youth, Havel made an unpredictable move. In 1977 the musicians were put on trial, first in Plzeň, then in Prague. He attended the second trial, in Prague, in which a member and the manager of the Plastics were accused of "disturbing the peace." Havel took the risk of publicly supporting their cause. Believing that they spoke a truth that was personally experienced and avouched, he signed a petition called Charter 77, linking the persecution of the musicians to the idea of human rights. "The freedom to play rock music," he wrote, "was understood as a human freedom and thus as essentially the same as the freedom to engage in philosophical and political reflection."

Havel became one of the spokespeople of the Charter 77 movement that emerged from the petition. Like his fellow spokesperson Jan Patočka, a noted philosopher, Havel wished to protect the self-education of young people. The musicians' ascent (in our terms) from sovereignty to unpredictability was the right kind of adulthood, precisely because it generated values that challenged older generations.

Patočka (1907–77) wished to protect the unpredictability of those much younger than himself. Taking the band name Plastic People of the Universe as an invitation to a philosophical riff, he called young musicians "our cosmonauts," generating values by remaining true to their young selves. In the essay, Patočka referred to two bands; the trial was directed at a more diffuse scene. The secret police interrogated Patočka for ten hours; he died shortly thereafter. Havel was sent to prison. It was after his involvement in protecting the musicians, and the corresponding term in prison, that Havel met Michnik in the mountains and wrote his anti-conformist essay.

Havel ended up writing about unpredictability thanks to his own unforeseen decision to risk his bodily freedom for the sake of others. "The Power of the Powerless" was a guide to the lure of unfreedom and a suggestion of how to become less probable. How did this text arise? Some people who were momentarily not in prison met on a mountaintop and talked. But what were the deeper sources of that encounter?

Human RightsSome causes lead us back to the Soviet Union, whose leader, ironically, wished to export predictability. As in its Czechoslovak satellite state, so in the USSR itself: after 1968, no one in power cared about Marxism. The dream of a communist future gave way to endorsement of the status quo, which Soviet leader Leonid Brezhnev called "really existing socialism."

Specifically, Brezhnev wanted acknowledgment of the Soviet empire gained by victory in the Second World War and consolidated by military actions in eastern Europe: antipartisan campaigns in Poland, the Baltic states, and Ukraine beginning in 1945, and invasions of East Germany in 1953, Hungary in 1956, Czechoslovakia in 1968. This he got. The Helsinki Final Act, signed in 1975, acknowledged the postwar territorial order and initiated new discussions on arms control. Soviet and east European communist rulers also signed on to a few paragraphs about human rights, which they considered meaningless.

The Helsinki Final Act affirmed the signatory states' commitment to earlier human rights treaties: the International

Covenant on Civil and Political Rights and the International Covenant on Economic, Social, and Cultural Rights. These were ratified by the Soviet Union and its communist satellites in early 1976, technically becoming the law of the land. Communist regimes lacked the rule of law; their constitutions gave the communist party a leading role in society, which nullified the rest of the document. But communists liked to pretend to abide by the law, and this created a certain opening for Havel, Patočka, and others.

Human rights meant a universal recognition of equal human dignity. Once that idea was formally incorporated as law, it became an argument for the legal autonomy of a citizen of an actual communist state. Communist regimes treated law as subordinate to the party, as the written emanation of the power relations of a given moment. But law could also be understood differently, as an aperture to a world of values, in which normal meant "following moral standards" rather than "accepting normalization." Courageous people in the USSR and throughout eastern Europe decided, in this spirit, to take their regimes' new legal obligations seriously. They saw in human rights an opportunity to draw attention to the plight of their friends, whose imprisonments for speaking and writing could be chronicled as violations of human rights.

In Moscow, the editors of a samizdat publication called the Chronicle of Current Events had since 1968 been using a language of human rights to report on conditions in the Soviet concentration camp system (the Gulag) and in Soviet psychiatric prisons. After the Helsinki Final Act, new groups were formed in Soviet Ukraine and throughout the satellite states with the purpose of recording human rights violations. After the two Covenants had been published in the official law gazette, Czechoslovak citizens formulated the Charter 77 petition to document the regime's violations of human rights. The Czechoslovaks who signed Charter 77 were taking part in a larger movement. Brezhnev's desire that nothing change led to a change of concepts.

This is not just irony, or what Marxists called dialectics. It is a reminder that what might seem normal, predictable, and inevitable can be resisted, and that resistance begins with a definition of what might be. Sovereign people will see chances where others might not and will help to wrench the rest of us from our most probable states.

Plastic PeopleThere would have been no trial, and no text, without the music. Another chain of causes that brought Czech musicians and thus Havel to that courtroom leads back to American history.

Rock and roll is part of the cultural aftermath of slavery, post–Civil War Reconstruction, and industrialization. It arose from the "race music," or rhythm and blues, of African Americans who moved to the industrializing North and met white audiences. Without that American encounter of the 1940s, rock and roll could not have been an important part of the alternative Czechoslovak culture of the 1970s.

A mediator between America and eastern Europe was a band called the Velvet Underground. Front man Lou Reed was a child of postwar American music—Little Richard, Ornette Coleman, Otis Redding, Al Green, Hank Williams, Elvis Presley. The Velvets were one of the most influential rock groups of all time—inspiring more bands than they sold records, as the saying went. One of these bands was the Plastic People of the Universe. The Plastics started covering the Velvets in 1968, the year Brezhnev ordered an invasion of Czechoslovakia, when violence begot "normalization." At that point, the Velvet Underground had released only two albums. For a couple of years, from 1970 to 1972, the lead singer of the Plastic People was the Canadian Paul Wilson, who could sing the English vocals of the Velvets.

The Velvet Underground was as New York as New York can be—but their trajectory owed something to eastern Europe. Reed was the grandchild of a Jewish family from the Russian Empire. The Velvet Underground was "managed" and their first album was "produced" by the pop artist Andy Warhol. The Velvets were the house band for Warhol's multimedia show The Exploding Plastic Inevitable. Warhol's parents spoke a Ruthenian (or Rusyn) dialect of Ukrainian. Like Havel's parents, they were born subjects of the old Habsburg monarchy, the central and east European empire that collapsed in 1918. Warhol's parents hailed from lands that became far eastern Czechoslovakia after 1918—and far western Soviet Ukraine in 1945. The recognition of the extended Soviet border was one of Brezhnev's goals at Helsinki.

The Plastic People of the Universe took their band's name from the song "Plastic People" written by Frank Zappa and performed by his band, the Mothers of Invention. ("I think that love will never be / a product of plasticity.") "Plastic People" was the first cut on the A side of the album Absolute Freedom.

The Mothers of Invention played “Plastic People” to the tune of “Louie Louie,” a song made famous to the point of prom-night cliché by the Kingsmen (who were once investigated by the FBI on the suspicion that the song’s incomprehensible lyrics might be obscene). As I did not know when dancing at my own prom, “Louie Louie” was written by Richard Berry, an African American born in Louisiana who made music in Los Angeles.

Berry penned the song on toilet paper in the bathroom of a club, having just heard “El Loco Cha Cha,” by René Touzet. The unforgettable hook of “Louie Louie” is lifted directly from Touzet’s composition. Touzet, for his part, was making a career in the United States after his club in Cuba was destroyed by a hurricane.

Without this improbable panoply, beginning with a hurricane (and therefore a butterfly?), there would have been no song titled “Plastic People,” and no band called the Plastic People of the Universe. We can see all this as a causal chain that begins with African American and Cuban music and leads to Havel and his commitment to human rights and his defense of unpredictability. But some of the links in the chain, taken in hand, prove to be woven of the supple stuff of accident and choice.

Zappa’s lyrics end with an admonition: “Go home, check yourself! You think we’re singing about someone else?” It is us or no one. Freedom is not a drama we watch. It is a play that we write on a stage that we build for an audience of everyone. Responsibility, said Patočka, is something we always carry with us. Patočka did not choose the circumstances that led to communism or to rock and roll, but he chose the occasion of the Plastics’ trial to write that “the only real help and care for others comes when I step forward and do what I have to do.”

Necessity is the mother of invention; the better we understand necessity, the more inventive we are. As we choose over time, working from the law of necessity to the law of freedom, we invent ourselves. As our choices mix with the universe, they render it more unpredictable, and us more responsible.

Normal DissidentsHavel did not like the word dissident because it suggested a separate vocation. He thought the “dissidents” were just being themselves, living their truths, sovereign and unpredictable. Dissidence was just a matter of trying to live according to virtues rather than conforming.

The virtues themselves need not be exalted ones. Havel’s two examples of dissidence in “The Power of the Powerless” were speaking up in your brewery about the quality of beer and taking down a propaganda sign from the window of your shop. Although Havel was a formidable dramatist writing in extreme conditions, the examples are human and accessible. The typical American of the 1980s knew nothing but bad beer. By the time I read the essay, I had worked cleanup on construction sites, in telemarketing, and in restaurants. The conformism of the workplace was easy to grasp.

Normal can mean what everyone does, as in normalization. But it can also mean what everyone should do. In his book on Poland’s Solidarity movement, Timothy Garton Ash gives the word to a Polish peasant who says normalnie! in the sense of “great!” Mariia of Posad Pokrovs’ke, when she asked me how I liked her little hut, actually said vse normalno? (“everything normal?”) in the sense of “as it should be.” She meant by normal not the routine of rubble around us but the virtuous order that a home represents. Human rights restored to the word normal its ethical direction: what one should be doing. Although the punishment for trying to live normally in this sense could be drastic, the self-presentation was modest.

The appeal of human rights throughout the communist bloc was this everyday humanity, the banality of good. Myroslav Marynovych, a member of the Ukrainian Helsinki Group, wrote of a normal Ukrainian life, where normal meant pursuing the activities that seemed normal to him, such as speaking or singing in his own language. Writing to his mother and sister from the Gulag in 1984, he spoke of “an embargo on normal human aspirations.” There is something fresh in the way that each of us combines values, and it was this freshness that was to be defended, not any sort of exalted abstraction.

Another human rights group, the Workers’ Defense Committee, was established in Poland in 1976. Polish workers striking against rising prices had been humiliated and imprisoned by the communist regime. The Workers’ Defense Committee found it abnormal that workers were beaten and fired by a regime that claimed to rule in their name, and normal that such workers would receive a legal defense and financial support. Human rights meant a handful of people trying to tell the truth about elemental matters, behave decently, and demonstrate solidarity. These realizations of human rights might seem prosaic: a defense of prisoners in Russia, of culture in Ukraine, of music in

Czechoslovakia, of labor in Poland.

The everyday quality of human rights was the point. It was not one ideology against another. The dissidents made no grand claims and advanced no grand worldviews but rather tried to tell everyday truths, advance everyday causes, realize everyday virtues. Human rights did not mean the self-contradictory determinist "freedom" in the communist (or capitalist) sense: it was not what happened automatically when private property was taken away (or restored). The notion of human rights did not defer or delegate freedom. It opened up the space for the human exploration of virtues. It stood for all the values that actual individuals living in an actual historical moment might choose to hold and to try to realize. People earned respect, not for making an argument against communism in favor of some alternative, but for "living in truth" (Havel) or for living "as if they were free" (Michnik).

If the cause was so humble, why did people go to prison (Havel, Michnik) or the Gulag (Marynovych) or even die (Patočka) for it? From the outside, sovereignty and unpredictability can look strange; someone is standing up or standing out for reasons that are not immediately clear. From the inside, they can feel like a need to act consistently with value choices made over the course of a life. As in Havel's case, an unexpected decision that attracts public attention can be preceded by years when nothing striking takes place. This was the point Zelens'kyi was trying to make to me in September 2022, when we spoke about dissidence, resistance, and his choice to remain in Kyiv at the beginning of the war. You feel free when your prior choices make sense of a moment. Your actions are then predictable to you, though unpredictable to the world.

An action that seems odd or risky from an external perspective can seem normal and necessary to the person concerned. The Welsh theologian Rowan Williams contended that "spiritual maturity" means that "there isn't very much choice." For him, "that's not a diminution but an expansion of the personal because here is someone who by a long and hard route has become someone whose seeing and responding is instinctively truthful. You don't have to think about it." Writing in prison, Havel put it this way: "By the fact that today I vouch for what I did yesterday, that I vouch here for what I did elsewhere, I acquire not only my identity but through it I am also located in space and time; if on the contrary I lose my identity, space and time must perforce also collapse around me."

When members of the Workers' Defense Committee, or Charter 77, or the Ukrainian Helsinki Group, were sentenced to prison in the 1970s and 1980s, they tended to say that they were only doing what they felt they had to do.

EmancipationThe unrest in eastern Europe in 1968 was not limited to the Czechs and Slovaks of the Prague Spring. In Warsaw, Polish students took to the streets that March to defend freedom of speech. And, of course, 1968 was a time of youthful revolution not only in eastern Europe but around the world. Events in Paris, Berlin, and Berkeley were no doubt more important for the dominant understanding of freedom.

The American, German, or French claim for emancipation from prior sexual and gender norms seemed radical and was significant. It, too, was a more than plausible understanding of the message of, say, the Velvet Underground. Yet emancipation is a negative notion of freedom: it is always "emancipation from" something. It does not call into question the whole structure; it asks instead for inclusion within it. It need not mean freedom for all; it tends to mean, rather, joining a set of emancipated groups. In 1968 it often meant "emancipation from the older generation."

Contrary to appearances, this notion of liberation lets the old off the hook. Because sovereignty and unpredictability require work over generations, freedom for each coming one will always depend (in part) on the actions of older people. If the older generation is just a barrier to be set aside, what comes next? The young who grow old consider that they have done their work of freedom when they, in their turn, get out of the way.

Many people formed by 1968 easily moved, in the 1970s and 1980s, from the idea of emancipation from the elders to the notion of emancipation from the government. This is the dead end of negative freedom, the notion that we are free if the government is small and weak. It delegitimates the assistance to families that children will need to have a chance at sovereignty and unpredictability. This move by the generation of 1968 made it harder for their own children and grandchildren to grow up free.

To be sure, many east European rebels also liked the idea that freedom was sexual and that sex brought emancipation from the stuffy older people. In Warsaw, the students beaten by batons looked different from the policemen doing the beating. One of the striking features of the Prague Spring was the long hair and the short skirts.

Beautiful youth irked Brezhnev, whose notion of communism was paternalistic and sexually repressive.

Young people in Prague got normalization, a consumerism without politics. This led some of them to creative thinking about freedom. In Warsaw, protesters were sent to prison, publicly shamed as Jews ("Zionists"), and told to leave the country. As in Czechoslovakia, the Polish communist authorities of the 1970s offered consumer goods in exchange for mindlessness. This led certain Poles, such as the dissident Adam Michnik, to argue that freedom resides in both rebellion and responsibility. That discussion about freedom crossed generations. Throughout eastern Europe, younger rebels looked for older mentors and found them.

Glass CaneIndividuality has to come from somewhere. The dissidents might have been sovereign and unpredictable, but they did not achieve this on their own. They were in milieus with recognized moral authorities, such as Jan Patočka for Havel or the philosopher Leszek Kołakowski for Michnik. Kołakowski was Poland's outstanding philosopher before being forced into exile after the events of 1968.

The "world of values," Kołakowski had written, is composed of "antagonistic elements which cannot all be recognized simultaneously, and each of which demands full recognition." Any single virtue has an absolute claim on us, but we can never realize it absolutely, not least because it clashes with other virtues. It is good to be consistent and good to be merciful, but nonsense to be consistently merciful, since to be merciful is to make an exception. It is good to be honest and good to be loyal, but over the course of a long friendship the statement "You're looking good" shifts from exemplifying the first virtue to exemplifying the second.

Totalitarianism offers an appealingly simple resolution: all the apparent diversity can be reduced to a single good. But this solution, said Kołakowski, is simply not true. The "world of values" is not a puzzle in which every piece has its proper place. There is no greater whole. Negative freedom also offers an easy dodge: once the barriers go down, all is permitted, and somehow all will be well. But this approach provides no definition of freedom and gives no sense of how a free person behaves. The story of freedom cannot be told without virtue, since freedom is the state in which we can affirm what we think is good and bring it into the world.

Aristotle was a value pluralist—like Kołakowski, he believed that there were many good things, not one or zero. When we are exercising judgment about which virtue applies in which situation, said Aristotle, we are doing right. This is true, but not quite all the truth. More than one virtue applies to almost any situation, so we have to choose. Since there are many good things, as Kołakowski argued, we must do some wrong even as we do right. The world of values is simply structured in this fashion. Since we are always deferring some virtue when we are affirming others, freedom assumes, in Kołakowski's words, "the reality of evil."

As we gather from his use of the word evil, Kołakowski's value pluralism means not relativism but a commitment to creative courage amid the clash of absolutes. We do right when we combine values and compromise with others, and when we accept that the concomitant evil leaves us responsible. As the philosopher Thomas Nagel concludes, "There can be good judgement without total justification." A graduate of my high school, Hannah Beachler, put it this way when she accepted an Oscar: "Do your best, and your best is good enough."

The possible combinations of virtues are infinite, and so our actions as free people are not predictable. Kołakowski also thought that we could invent new virtues, and that they were the most important ones. They emerge when we do things that no one has the right to expect of us. His value pluralism was an adventure directed toward the future. We believe in the possibility of new values because we believe that there is new good to be discovered in the world. This adds still another layer of unpredictability.

Leszek Kołakowski (1927–2009) was formed as a young man by the German occupation of Poland, and he married a Holocaust survivor. He met his future wife, Tamara, in 1948 when, as a student, she sought him out in a café in Warsaw to ask his advice about an exchange program.

Tamara was from Łódź, only about a hundred miles from Warsaw, but she had already journeyed thousands of miles before enrolling as a student. She was alive because her family had fled Łódź all the way to Uzbekistan. Before the Holocaust, Łódź had been one of the great Jewish cities of Europe, home to about as many Jews as Palestine. When she returned after the war, she found that "all of our Łódź family had perished. Three girls from my class at school survived." She married Leszek in 1949, left Poland with him in 1968, and remained with him to the end of his life. In her memoir, Tamara entitled the chapter in which she met her future husband "Accident," but it was accident

followed by commitment.

Shakespeare has Hamlet say: “Where joy most revels, grief doth most lament / Grief joys, joy grieves, on slender accident.” There is chance in the universe, and there are chances that we take. Kołakowski wrote, “My existence is realized only as permanent contact with the border of the unpredictable.” When I knew him at Oxford and afterward, his rueful but mischievous smile reminded me that life can be full of rough chances, which we soften with humane choices.

Each of us enchants the world unpredictably or not at all. Kołakowski enchanted with a black hat, a glass cane, and a lopsided smile. He wrote me letters by hand, with a form of address that suggested interbellum collegiality. When we met, he would point the cane at my chest, smile, and call out “Snyder!” as if my existence made the world slightly richer, or at least slightly more comical. That made me smile, too.

No God, no person, no machine could have anticipated my teacher’s marriage, his glass cane, or his lopsided smile, or what I do with his teaching: that, for example, I would go from writing about Marxism, one of Kołakowski’s subjects, to writing about the Holocaust, a subject of his wife’s memoir—or for that matter, that my own wife would write the book that Tamara would read to Leszek in his final days.

What I write is unpredictable, but it is not random. It rests in larger structures, physical and moral, even as it acts within them and alters them. It owes something to twentieth-century people whom I admired. It expresses values that I have learned from the past (when else?), which I am combining and applying in my own particular way. This chapter, about unpredictability in the twenty-first century, is what I must write.

ServantI read those nice letters from Leszek Kołakowski in a dodgy student hostel in Warsaw, with leaky pipes and frequent breakins. As I carried out research for my dissertation in 1992 and 1993, I limited my possessions to what fit in a backpack, which I placed under my pillow at night to prevent theft. The most important thing I owned was the heavy gray Apple laptop I carried with me to the archives. My friend Andrzej Waśkiewicz, a Polish social thinker, would point to my computer and ask, “Kto komu służy?”

Who is serving whom? Is the human serving the machine, or is the machine serving the human? At that point, before wi-fi and smartphones, I could set the backpack in a corner of Andrzej’s tiny apartment, one object among others, have a beer or three, play darts, and talk. During a brief visit to the United States in May 1993, my laptop was stolen, along with all the backup copies of my dissertation research. On my way to a New Haven crack house to try to get it back, Andrzej’s question came to mind, an unbidden memory. Panting as I ran, I still had to laugh.

To be sure, machines can serve our purposes, enabling us to assert our own values. I did get the computer and the research back, and I did write my dissertation on it. Tony Judt and I communicated by email attachment as we edited our conversations into a book. My 2017 pamphlet On Tyranny began as a Facebook post. Right after the 2020 presidential election, when I told American CEOs to prepare for a coup attempt by Donald Trump, I was on Zoom. A class I taught at Yale on Ukraine in fall 2022 reached millions of people thanks to YouTube and Spotify and Apple podcasts.

I don’t always succeed, but I try to keep in mind Andrzej’s who/whom question. I try to see the computer in front of me as a tool to reach other people, and to motivate them to think or act differently. I know that readers of On Tyranny took action on the streets and in parliaments. On the basis of my notes, the CEOs quickly drafted a statement about respecting the outcome of the 2020 presidential election that became a model for others and that made it harder for Trump to stage his coup. That said, I would not have had to resort to the internet for these defensive maneuvers if Trump had not been elected, and had democracy around the world not crashed—developments enabled by social media.

I might be able to turn the machine to my purposes, and I know that others do. I fear, though, that overall the machine creates a special kind of entropy (Havel) or gravity (Weil). Because portable networked microprocessors—our ever-present phones, tablets, and laptops—can seem to do everything, they draw us into a messy mental world where we are not sure what we are doing. We leave behind the gifts of the Leib as we retreat toward the more predictable Körper. We lose our quiet, individual why amid the superabundance of how. And then the world shifts.

Who is serving whom? Or what? The purpose of most tools is self-evident. As Martin Burckhardt points out, the

networked microprocessor has no clear purpose; it is less a tool for us than an invitation to us, or a seduction of us. It can be a pan-tool, capable of everything; but also an anti-tool, making its users less rather than more capable. If we do not thoughtfully engage the machines, we will find that they are disengaging us: from one another, from our values, even from our bodies.

BiographyWe have to be very mindful if we want to assert our purposes through social media. We have to manipulate software that is designed to manipulate us. If we are not careful, social media will turn our sovereign capacities to declare and accommodate against us, leaving us predictable and easy to rule. This is, sadly, not a hypothesis. Surveilled, harried, and nudged, I am undoubtedly less free than I was when I was sitting in Andrzej's apartment, backpack set aside, computer quiet in a corner. We are all less free.

In remembering that scene, I am freer than I would be had I forgotten it. Freedom involves possible futures, unpredictable to aspiring tyrants and uncaring machines. And any plausible future must be connected to a remembered or historical past. Knowledge of the past is therefore a reservoir of power and self-liberation. The future might flow down many channels, but its sources are in the past. Many things are possible, but not everything is possible. When we know nothing about the past, we think anything is possible but are quickly disillusioned. When we know something about the past, we know about some things that might be possible, and we have a chance at realizing them, a chance at freedom.

An element of ironic unpredictability in my own career is that unemployment enabled my historical work. I spent most of the first half of the 1990s in England, Poland, and France, writing a dissertation. After I finished my doctoral degree, I was unable to find a job as a professor for six years, so I spent much of the rest of the 1990s living in Warsaw, Prague, and Vienna, with journeys elsewhere in the region, including Belarus and Ukraine. I read books, learned languages, had some fellowships, translated for pay, and did other gig work. Living in Europe, I appreciated the access to public health systems. I suffered from disabling migraines and tended to break bones but did not have to worry about whether a doctor would see me.

As a result of some luck, I finally did get a job, at Yale. This had little to do with any merits of mine, or with any logic of hiring in American universities. It had been in New Haven that my laptop (with my dissertation research) had been stolen, and it was in New Haven that I was able to publish the next book, The Reconstruction of Nations, about Poland, Lithuania, Belarus, and Ukraine. Though it concerned the grand question of the origins of the modern nation, it was populated with unpredictable characters who saw the larger processes and worked with them. Like my later book Bloodlands, which was a history of Nazi and Soviet mass killing policies, it drew heavily from the time I had spent in the territories it described.

I was attracted to the unfashionable genre of biography, which captures some of the unpredictability that is essential to history—to what actually happened. Individuality tends to get washed out by retrospective accounts of what must have been according to the schemes we happen to believe right now. Writing about individuals restores some of the richness of the past and makes the present and future seem more open to choice. My dissertation had been a biography of a Polish Marxist exiled from his homeland by Russian imperial oppression. In New Haven, I wrote biographies of a Polish scenographer who plotted Ukrainian independence, and a Habsburg archduke, Wilhelm, who wished to become king of Ukraine.

MaidanWilhelm von Habsburg's was an unpredictable sort of life; it ended in prison after interrogation by the Soviet secret state police. He signed his interrogation protocols with his chosen Ukrainian name, Vasyl Vyshyvanyi. His chosen nation, Ukraine, has taken on a significance that few had foreseen.

After the end of the USSR in 1991, most people continued to speak of Moscow and Russia, but in some respects Kyiv and Ukraine were more important. Historians appreciated that Ukraine kept its archives open; this seemingly small and everyday fact is at the root of much that we have learned about the Soviet Union. Protesting for freedom of speech and the counting of votes in the 2000s, Ukrainian citizens established a functioning democratic system. By the early twenty-first century, most Ukrainians were thinking of Europe as their political future. For Ukrainians growing up after the end of the Soviet Union, the European Union generally meant freedom, the possibility of a life with better prospects, less bounded by a Soviet past.

In November 2013, as Ukraine was about to enter into an agreement with the European Union, Putin managed, through bribery and blackmail, to dissuade the Ukrainian president from signing the relevant document. By then, all

major Russian television stations issued coordinated propaganda. The message in late 2013 and early 2014 was that Ukraine did not really exist, and that Ukrainians and Russians were one people. I predicted on that basis that Russia would invade Ukraine, which it later did. I was apparently alone in doing so, at least in prominent forums. It was perhaps important that I was not on social media and was instead listening to people who were in Kyiv and attending closely to Russian propaganda. The same held later for my prediction in 2020 that Trump would try a coup, which he did. I just listened to what he said.

In Ukraine, the pro-European protests of 2013 were led at first by students and young people, those who had the most to lose if Europe was out of reach. After the students were beaten by riot police, the journalist Mustafa Nayyem summoned people to Kyiv's Independence Square, known as the Maidan. Nayyem closed his Facebook post with the words "Likes don't count"—only living bodies count, only the Leib counts. He was using the machine for an unintended purpose. The rule of law and human dignity would be protected, in the last instance, by the assembly of human bodies in a public place.

Isolation and algorithmic targeting summon the predictable Körper; people meeting one another rediscover the Leib. On the Maidan over the next few months, new and durable friendships were made. People founded civil society organizations that led to habits of cooperation and trust that would endure when Russia invaded Ukraine first in February 2014 and then in February 2022. In May 2014, along with friends and colleagues, I invited intellectuals, journalists, and policymakers from Europe and North America to Kyiv for a conference called Ukraine: Thinking Together. Its premise was that people who saw what was happening for themselves would understand better than people who stayed behind screens.

The idea for that conference began when friends in America called me in the middle of the night in London, and I realized, in the disinhibition of half-sleep, what had to be done. Colleagues and I organized the Kyiv gathering in a few turbulent and largely sleepless weeks, and my recollections are a little blurry. What everyone seems to remember is that I did some of the live interpretation and that I made the coffee. I don't remember deciding to do those things. I had waited tables before. I had interpreted before. I was doing what I had chosen and what I could, which was what I had to do.

The circumstances that bring us together are unpredictable. And then in our encounter we bring unpredictability to one another. At the same time, in order to be together, we all need certain things: the time, the space, the language, the capabilities. It took work to get everyone together at that time and place. But I was animated by purposes that I understood and aided by institutions that others had made. I certainly felt free.

ConfinementThat conference in Kyiv was the first time my wife and I had both spent nights away from our children. My son had just turned four, and my daughter was not yet two. (And so there was a babysitter back in Vienna, of course. My wife had left the kids with me previously, which prompted this stunned reaction from a female east European colleague: "You left your children with a man?") Russia had invaded Ukraine, but the front was hundreds of miles away. We were in no danger in Kyiv in May 2014, but we were there to think about (and think with) people who had taken risks with their bodies. A poet and novelist I admired, Serhiy Zhadan, had refused to kneel before Russians in Kharkiv—and got his skull broken. His personal courage, as real as the batons, was part of what brought me to Kyiv. The young historian Bohdan Solchanyk was critical of my approach in Bloodlands, thinking that I had not gone local enough, had not accounted for specific motives of specific perpetrators. He had a point, though I never had a chance to talk to him about it. Bohdan was murdered by a sniper as Russia invaded Ukraine.

Another young Ukrainian historian later remarked that in Bloodlands I attended only to policies of mass killing, leaving incarceration in the background. This was true: I wanted my book on mass killing to have a clear focus and thought that the familiar notions of "Gulag" and "terror" overshadowed policies of political murder. When he made the point, Zhenya Monastyrs'kyi was speaking from experience. He had been taken prisoner during the first Russian invasion. The improvised jail in which he had been kept was part of a growing system of holding facilities, concentration camps, and torture chambers that Russia built (and builds) in the Ukrainian territories that it has seized since 2014.

Prison is a traditional place to contemplate freedom. Writings by prisoners help us to consider confinement not only as a set of barriers around the individual but as a specific condition of the human body. From the beginning, prisoners themselves have documented the vulnerability of the Leib to too little human contact—and to too much. In the first important book about Russian prison, the novel-as-memoir Notes from a Dead House, Fyodor Dostoevsky

complained of “forced communal living,” the unceasing presence of bodies not chosen for their company. James Davis III made the point that prison is an “unnatural space peopled by so many men, too many men.” In the first important book about American prison, the memoir-as-novel The Life and Adventures of a Haunted Convict, Austin Reed complained of solitary confinement. The philosopher Lisa Guenther argued that our need for encounter makes forced solitude a specifically inhumane torture.

When kept in isolation, Zhenya recited poetry to keep his sanity. Solitary confinement is bad, but sharing a cell meant for one person is also bad. Those who oppress us either sever or overload the Leib’s connection to the world. As my students in the American prison explained to me, they do both, one after the other. There can be too much and there can be too little, with never a moment of just right. I hoped that our class provided such a moment.

CellyWhereas in American English a celly is a cellmate in prison, outside the United States it can be slang for a cell phone. Watching people leave their cells and get cell phones can be disconcerting. A former prisoner released in the early 2020s asked a reasonable question about his new iPhone: “How do I get this thing away from my face?”

Another formerly incarcerated person I know, a man about my age, began his sentence in the twentieth century, well before smartphones were invented. When he was released after twenty-six years, he was troubled by the spectacle of people staring at the little screens. “I’ve seen more unfree people out here than I ever saw inside” was his comment. When I repeated it, that remark annoyed some of my incarcerated students: a touchscreen is no prison wall. But the perspective of the middle-aged man who had never encountered the portable internet is valuable: it provides a view of what has happened to us, from someone who was not eased gradually into our brave new world but encountered it all at once.

The algorithms of social media keep us online with a painfully elegant formula: too much contact with (apparent) others in the form of rapid affirmation, yet also too little contact with the actual Leib of actual humans. We feel as though we are recognizing and learning, but without the Leib we are disoriented, stressed, and prone to poor judgments about ourselves. We get used to all the dopamine hits, but they are delivered without any bodily sense. We get more psychological reinforcement from the device than we could possibly get in real life—and then get depressed because all the contact lacks tangibility. That experience of too much and too little leaves us trapped.

What might seem like a quaint human detail, that we spend ever more time looking at ever more seductive content, changed the world in the mid-2010s. The tipping of one convention into another, from looking at people to looking at screens, enabled a whole series of events that would otherwise have been impossible. In 2014, I realized that the actual stories of actual Ukrainians counted for little in the public conversation about the war, because mechanically amplified prejudices took up all the space. I started writing a book then, The Road to Unfreedom, about the hybrid tyranny that was emergent in Russia and its spread westward.

In 2016, exactly the same Russian institutions exploited exactly the same social media strategies to attack Hillary Clinton. Some Americans were told over social media that Clinton was a racist, others that she liked Black criminals. The contradiction did not matter, just as it had not mattered with respect to the 2014 Russian invasion of Ukraine, because the different messages were targeted at different people. An important Russian actor in the campaigns of 2014 and 2016 was Yevgeny Prigozhin, who ran Russia’s Internet Research Agency. Prigozhin also directed a private military company called Wagner. (The name is the call sign of its founder, a Russian Nazi, who meant it as a reference to Hitler.) During the full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Wagner recruited tens of thousands of incarcerated Russians to fight and die in Ukraine.

It is disturbing to think that our emotions, and even our actions, arise from the work of such people. But they do, and that makes us less free. Our emotions can be automated because our networked portable microprocessors ceaselessly communicate data about us. It is easy to calculate our vulnerabilities—to find our most probable states. When my Ukrainian student Zhenya was taken prisoner, he managed to erase his cell phone data while locked in the trunk of a car, so that he would not put his friends in danger. On a macro scale, though, we cannot easily protect others or ourselves. The agglomeration of data about our social media use makes us vulnerable, as groups, to targeted propaganda.

Data collection can become the structure of unfree politics. China has a smaller incarceration system (at least officially and proportionate to its population) than America or Russia; perhaps this is because the entire country is a kind of prison. Chinese authorities judge you quantitatively, with a numerical rating that determines which spaces

your body can inhabit. Your body, rather than enabling unpredictable connections to others, becomes a part of a system of measurement. Your qualities are turned back into quantities and turned against your freedom. The physical world closes down around you. In a certain way, every citizen of China then becomes a celly.

Lost Time"Do the time, don't let the time do you" is a phrase I learned in a prison, but it has a broader application. When we are not thoughtful about how we engage with social media, time is one of the first things we lose.

We give away the hours of the day. Our time without the machine is broken up by our time with it. Even if we are not using a phone or tablet, we forget what we are doing when we see one. If someone else glances at a device, we look at our own. We live as if in suspension, awaiting an interruption. In everyday life, our sense of time dissolves into a permanent rush. Even the precious moments just after wakefulness and just before sleep are sacrificed in the tiny glow. A Leib needs sleep in order to be sovereign and unpredictable; when we give sleep away to the screens, we are less ourselves and less free. Few things are more important than sleep to our maturation, happiness, and memory. Sleep has been the quiet casualty of our unfreedom.

For humans, time can resolve itself into subjective moments that we experience and then can remember. We lose time by not focusing, by not encoding moments from the flux. Simone Weil thought the "quantity of creative genius of an epoch" was measured by attention span. By her measure (and our own), we are becoming stupider. The twenty-first century is, let's face it, very dumb. Much is wrong with IQ tests, but the people who praise the digital world seem to approve of them. They like to speak of the Flynn Effect of increasing IQs. This is odd, since the internet age is in fact the time of the Reverse Flynn Effect, of decreasing IQs. We may have already dropped through the floor, too dumb to see how dumb we have become.

Time is also the time of life. Our sense of the continuity of our own biographies comes from our unpredictable capacity to go back and forth, to recall what was encoded, to link memory to experience. Some conjuncture in the present summons a rich memory of the past, perhaps of something we did not know we remembered—a taste of watermelon, a glimpse of sky, the sound of gravel under tires, the lyric of a song, the voice of a friend. The lines cast back are unpredictable, and yet very real, substantiating the present and thus the future. The solidity of those unexpected passages back ensures the navigability of our individual way forward. These involuntary memories are another form of time that the machine lacks and tends to deny us.

On social media, our attention is divided into fragments that are the right size for analysis of us but not by us. Our minds flutter hither and thither, landing nowhere. Attention is no longer about a special state of mind but about eyeballs on screens. Things get our attention, but we no longer pay attention. And then we do not remember. When memory fails, our future has no past, and we are not really present.

Regained TimeAn involuntary memory can move us to see, think, write. Where did my bicentennial bell come from? As a three-dimensional object, it has its own trajectory in the fourth dimension of time: forged in Cincinnati; hung in a one-room schoolhouse at an intersection of country roads; one farm; another farm. It did stand next to the farmhouse in 1976, and I did grasp the pull and ring it. That happened. But how does my past reach me? How do I get back to a moment? How do we regain time? How does the bell mean something to me, stand for other things, appear in the fifth dimension? Unpredictably.

At around the time I rang that bell in Ohio, and the Plastic People of the Universe were arrested in Czechoslovakia, a teenager called Michael Stipe happened across a Velvet Underground album in the discount pile of a record store in southern Illinois. The band he started in 1980, R.E.M., was one of many with debts to the Velvet Underground. They covered four of the Velvets' songs, and Stipe would later cover a fifth.

My youngest brother discovered R.E.M. in 1984. We had a copy of their albums Murmur and Reckoning on cassette tape and excitedly bought Fables of the Reconstruction when it was released in 1985. I was fascinated by the cut "Driver 8," a song about trains, with the lyric "The children look up, all they hear is (sky blue) bells ring." Rightly or wrongly, I always heard "sky blue" not as the color of the bells, but as the color the children saw when they looked up. I was reminded of something: darkness, a loud peal, blue skies. I couldn't quite place it.

In September 1986, after R.E.M. released Lifes Rich Pageant, my father drove my two brothers and me to Cincinnati to see their concert at the Taft Theater. "Driver 8" was the fifth song R.E.M. played. "The children look up, all they hear is (sky blue) bells ring." Hearing those words with my brothers, I suddenly recalled being in line with them ten

years before, leaning back, hearing the bell, and seeing the sky. What if we hadn't seen that show? What if Michael Stipe had never pulled the Velvet Underground album from the discount bin? What if my grandfather had never hung that bell? Where would this book be?

The unpredictability of biography flows into the unpredictability of history.

In September 1989, not long after a non-communist government formed in Poland, I listened to R.E.M. close a concert with a Velvet Underground cover. A week before the first big march in Prague, R.E.M. played "After Hours" again. The Czechoslovak protests that autumn were called the Velvet Revolution. They ended with Havel as president. Havel would never have reached the presidential palace without his decision to defend the Plastics, and the Plastics would never have been a band without the Velvets.

Nor would R.E.M. have existed without the Velvets, and so neither would I, at least not the I who listened to the music, remembered the bell, and wrote these lines.

As a graduate student in England, I had the CD of R.E.M.'s Automatic for the People. Once I was listening to it while I read a text Havel had written as president. The translator was Paul Wilson, once the Plastics' lead singer. But who was translating whom, really? Havel would not have become the president writing that text without Wilson's Lou Reed imitation a quarter-century earlier.

In 2018 I was asked to write a new introduction to Paul Wilson's translation of "The Power of the Powerless," where I tried to formulate an argument about unpredictability. I met Paul in person in Prague in 2019; at a conference about Havel in Maine in 2022 I talked to him about music and chance. Right before that, I had been in Kyiv, asking Volodymyr Zelens'kyi how he defined freedom. And he said, "We all have our own values. Live in truth. Maybe you want to play the guitar. Learn to play the guitar. Start a band."

As the soft circles of memory open and close, we regain time. The chaos melds back together with choices, yielding a sovereign, unpredictable self. The machines corral us in harder pens: race, sex, income, residence. They define us by our most probable states, by what we do online or under surveillance, not by what we do on the mountaintops or under the water or when the music is loud or in our dreams. The algorithms get in among people and transform the energy of the Leib into enervation for the Körper. We don't encode what happens, or we don't recall what we encoded. The gossamer whirl of memory flattens on the screen.

Inhuman BarriersWhen I saw R.E.M. perform in 1986, 1987, 1989, and 1995, I was in high school, college, and graduate school. No one expected much of me. Now I love live performance because someone else is occupying the stage. I empathize with artists acquitting themselves with their bodies of what they owe to their art, bringing what they have within to an audience awaiting without.

Teaching is performance, and it is work. The screens make my job harder. I have taught kids to read and to field ground balls. I have taught computer languages, Slavic languages, English as a foreign language. I have taught theater to kindergarteners and philosophy to prisoners. I earn my living as a history professor behind the lectern.

But where is that lectern today, in almost every American university classroom? As I travel around the United States for invited lectures, I notice the same shift everywhere. The lectern has been moved from center stage to extreme stage left, so that the human lecturer does not block the students' view of the huge, wall-sized screen where slides are to be projected. People pay me to speak, then bargain down the time of my lecture, then ask me for my slides (which I never have). The daring impulse of inviting a stranger to lecture gives way to increasing fear that something might actually be said.

We are being tamed by the machine, dulled to one another. The American university class is yielding to the screen, to the cave, to the death principle. Let us all pretend that something is happening while another hour passes, do that for four years, get the piece of paper, and move on to a world of further fakery. The university should enliven, and at its best it still does; certainly there is no substitute for it. But teaching is about the Leib, not the machine.

At the World Economic Forum in Davos, the pressure to have a visual presentation is intense. Flashy presentations are called "memorable," but no one actually remembers their content. I never use visuals, and people report that, to their own astonishment, they actually remember what I have said from year to year. I once had the rare pleasure, at

Davos, of taking part in an event with two other historians, both of whom shared my attitude and refused to use slides and screens. The outcome was a rapt audience. In boardrooms as well as classrooms, elite and less so, machines stupefy. When the lights dim and the first slide goes up, we relax into zombified calm, knowing that nothing lively is expected of us.

In hospitals, patients are separated from nurses and doctors by giant computer caddies or handheld digital apparatuses. The screen has the power to separate people even when they are in the same place. The time we spend every day with screens teaches us to disregard our bodies, which is preparation for their disregard by others. We fail to notice when machines occupy space needed by our bodies, even when our lives depend on it.

Rationalizing ZombiesOur thinkers can help us resist predictability. Stein argued that bodily empathy leads us toward reasonability. Weil made the case that our corporeality allows us to ask the important questions. Kołakowski said that human existence is about pushing beyond the edge of a predictable world into one that is not. Havel warned that we can be tempted into thinking like machines, or even into thinking that we are machines. All of them insisted on the why, on the search for the "world of values."

As we engage with the digital world, we grow comfortable with the how questions, the inhuman ones, and we find awkward the why questions, the human ones involving judgments about good and evil. We phrase how questions in terms of "efficiency," "maximization," and "optimization." The idiom of productivity is senseless in itself; it can be meaningful only when we know what we value. No notion of means-ends rationality (if you value a, you should do b) coheres without a value judgment; no amount of how can get you to why.

The how questions generate quantitative propositions that computer programs can handle. As we translate the experience of life into machine language, we risk our minds becoming something like satellite servers to make things easier for the computers—which do not and cannot care. When we confuse the convenient with the significant, the death principle descends like a cold fog.

A major political challenge in this century is to get out from under the legacy of empire, a theme of the next chapter, on mobility. And yet we seem to be building a new sort of empire instead. Frantz Fanon, the psychiatrist and anti-colonial thinker, observed that empire transforms humans from why creatures into how creatures. A colonizer portrays other colonizers as having agency, and colonized people as without agency, and therefore as instruments. As we lose our sense of why, we are being colonized by our machines—with the vertiginous twist that our mechanical colonizers have no agency. We are submitting to an entity that cannot even enjoy its domination.

Simone Weil predicted that "capitalism will be succeeded by oppression exercised in the name of function." In "surveillance capitalism," as Shoshana Zuboff rightly calls it, rationality means constant monitoring, so that an invisibly tiny group of people can profit. Their empire is not visible in territory like the empires of old, and they (usually) stash their wealth in tax shelters rather than flaunting it in marble palaces. The digital oligarchs themselves often have no idea what they are doing, aside from indulging in some vague competition with one another. They monopolize everyone's future and fill it with inbred silliness.

When we forget the why and have only the how, our imagination seeps into the gully of the status quo. We rationalize, using our residual intelligence to explain that the world cannot be otherwise than it is, and that we cannot do otherwise than we have done.

In so doing, we collaborate in our own unfreedom. Taking responsibility for past decisions is necessary for constructing future freedom; if we rationalize the past, we are trapped in a story, a narrative of what must be that others will use against us. Our digital nemesis (and its human acolytes) train us to be "rational," in just that sense of rationalization, of making excuses for the very process that is humiliating us. We are to accept the world as the elites and the machines have given it to us, and we are to praise our ascribed place. Such self-subjugation is a return to a feudal world, in which a divine order has been replaced by a digital one, one sort of priest by another. This is not enlightenment but darkness.

Weil warned that the how of life can crowd out the why, that "utility becomes something which the intelligence is no longer entitled to define or to judge, but only to serve." When humans call on other humans to turn their minds into rationalization circuits, the gist is that we should be functional, like machines. We should sacrifice the capacities that make us different from computers and instead become poor imitations of them. Rather than seeking freedom by

thinking reasonably with facts and values, we fade into the status quo. We should not call into question the parameters of our existence but simply make the best of what we are given.

Freedom is positive; it needs the vivifying world of values. If we have no purpose, we serve someone else's, or we serve a purposeless machine. We have been assigned a senseless task: to adjust, to adapt, to normalize, to internalize the death principle before we die, to regard ourselves not as Leib but as Körper, to consider ourselves as nothing better than a computer simulation, to die without having lived, to self-zombify.

A human intelligence that asks why before it asks how, that is directed toward freedom rather than utility, is not rational so much as reasonable. It does not waste its energy rationalizing the existing state of affairs or its own weakness. It reasons instead, with the help of values and others, toward better futures. It operates in the borderland of unpredictability, considering values and facts. It seeks to understand the world as it is and to bend it toward the way it should be.

Brain HacksIt is hard to be free alone, sovereign alone, unpredictable alone. If I ever became reasonable, it was thanks to people around me, neighboring sources of human intelligence. When I was with my teacher Leszek Kołakowski, or even when I read his books today, I have a sense that I am in "contact with the border of the unpredictable." Free people who push up against that border are expanding the fifth dimension, the realm of virtues.

To throw our weight in that direction, to become free, we have to recognize the sources of predictability and our vulnerability to them.

When we understand the physical regularities outside ourselves, we can turn them to our own purposes. We cannot wish gravity out of existence or claim that it is just one opinion among others. If we exploit what we know about it, we can (to take a simple example) build counterweights and elevate. Elevators use gravity against itself, so to speak. Every step we take as we walk (or move in a wheelchair or on crutches) is a negotiation with gravity; we are free insofar as we move without thinking. The restraints of the universe are also opportunities in a broader sense: gravity, which seems to hold us down, is also the source of the energy and diversity that enables life and grace.

We must also understand the regularities of the built mental world around us, the network of microprocessors within which we spend so much of our lives. We can use that world in many ways, including some that allow us to realize our values. But there is, as yet, no equivalent in the digital world to walking, no form of engagement in which our knowledge of what we are doing fades into healthy habits. The rules of the digital world can be altered and must be.

Until then, social media's pulse of predictability will draw us in. The algorithms locate the parts of us that are most predictable, nourishing them until they suppress our character. They carry out what the mathematician Ada Lovelace (1815–52) long ago called a "calculus of the nervous system." Their dread superpower is to predictify, to dominate people by making them predictable as individuals and classifiable as groups. One mind at a time, this nemesis pushes the border of the unpredictable back, contracting the fifth dimension, making us unfree. When we see ourselves as Körper, we might not see the problem; when we see ourselves as Leib, we do.

We can use what we know about the mind to make ourselves sovereign and unpredictable. But we can also use such knowledge to find brain hacks that disable many human beings for the profit of the few. Social media draw from such knowledge. Facebook (and other social media) exploits brain hacks that arose decades ago in laboratories full of rats and pigeons.

Experimental IsolationIn one set of experiments, a lone animal was placed before a lever, which might or might not (depending on the experiment) release a pellet of food. The purpose was to ascertain whether the animal was intelligent, in the sense of being able to understand the connection between pushing the lever and getting the food. Although it was not initially appreciated, the isolation of the animal was crucial to the results of the experiment. This experiment continues every time you place yourself in front of a display connected to a networked microprocessor. You, too, are being tested, on the basis of what was learned from the animals.

The first brain hack is experimental isolation, getting you alone, out of bodily contact with your fellow creatures. It generates an artificial loneliness that enables four more brain hacks, four more kinds of manipulation.

In the experiments, the isolated rat or pigeon works one end of the tool but does not see its other end, nor the actions

and intentions of the experimenters. We similarly set our eyes on the display of a computer or a phone. We are ignorant of what lies on the other side: the tangle of algorithms, the vacuum of purpose. Fingertips on a keyboard, we fall into a trap. We speak of “my computer” or “my phone,” but these objects are not ours, any more than the lab belongs to the rat—unless we figure out how they work on us.

Could animals tap a lever to get food? They could. In a variation of these experiments, pushing the lever might or might not yield a pellet of food. This led to a finding that has served advertising and oppression ever since.

Facing a device that sometimes but not always reacts to action by releasing a source of pleasure, the animal in the experiment will push the lever over and over, forgetting everything else. In this artificial situation, the external world has all the unpredictability, and the poor animal is suffering and predictable. Intermittent reinforcement is the second brain hack. It depends on experimental isolation—if the animal has company, the device is less beguiling.

We overestimate the difference between ourselves and other animals at our peril. Identifying with their predicaments can sometimes help us to understand our own. After all, the box into which we dropped rats or pigeons was the template for the computer programs that seem to dominate our lives. They are designed to isolate and then deliver intermittent reinforcement.

Though clearly disabling for the animals, intermittent reinforcement was lumped together with “rationality” as a normal way to treat people. It would be “rational” for people who control systems to intermittently reinforce others in this way, to get them to gamble at slot machines or to buy things. From gambling and advertising, isolation and intermittent reinforcement spread to social media, where the profit model is to keep you online to view advertisements. Social media dose you with what you like—and then, occasionally, with what you fear. The paradigm in which these experiments were developed, known as behaviorism, was indifferent to motives and purposes, let alone values and virtues. Those who exploit its findings tend to present why questions as signs of irrationality.

Some animals might be wiser than we are. When octopuses were subjected to behaviorist experiments, they reacted with less interest than did rats and pigeons. The octopuses seemed to understand that they were in a made environment and wished to pass judgment on their predicament. In one case, an octopus tried to break the machine, then raised itself out of the pool to squirt water at the experimenter. From this behavior, the human scientists concluded that octopuses were not rational—a conclusion that suggests their own mental limits. Such behaviors perhaps demonstrate that octopuses are reasonable, in the sense of judging an overall situation and reacting. We should be more like that.

Behaviorism can be applied to politics, as, for example, in the communist “normalization” that Havel described. Late communism was based on the assumption that people were beasts without values, easily manipulated to work for the few. Its logic was simple: give people what they want some of the time; throw in some fear; never ask what it all means, and make sure no one else does either. The totalitarian dream having proven empty, the single value of communism having been abandoned, communists shifted to zero values and intermittent reinforcement. Our silicon prophets have followed the same arc from hysteria to nihilism. There is no innovation in the ideas on offer, only familiar pyrite baubles rolled downhill into dreary disillusionment.

Havel saw in the normalized Czechoslovakia of the 1970s a “warning to the West, revealing to it its own latent tendencies.” He thought that late communism presented the typical modern problem of “unfreedom” wherein we participate by reacting predictably to a pattern of stimuli. Experimental isolation and intermittent reinforcement bring us to our most probable states.

Icy TumultWhen we think with values, we are drawing from the past, but we are not stuck in it. We are considering the present, but we are not sanctifying it. We are oriented toward the future, and we are making it.

We like to think of ourselves as reasonable creatures, and sometimes we are. Our individual reasonability is unpredictable, because it arises in unique combinations of facts that we find salient and values that we affirm. Our collective unreasonability is predictable, because (unlike values and facts) impulses and lies can be mechanized. Our collective unreasonability has general patterns, which computers trace and amplify. It is not so much that they outthink us; they unthink us.

One form this unreasonability takes is confirmation bias. This means that we treat information as evidence when it seems to confirm what we already believe. In our better moments, we are aware of this tendency and try to correct for it: by creating political institutions that confront us with the opinions of others; by following social conventions that generate exchanges of views; by forcing ourselves to hear someone out; by having friends from different backgrounds; or by reading a surprising book.

Confirmation bias is an easy seam for a brain hack. The program simply follows where we click and nudges us along. It supplies more of the same, attaching a bit more emotional content. It keeps our eyes on the screen, while making us narrow-minded and sure of ourselves. Everything we feel turns out to be true and important. This gets worse as search engines merge with "AI" text-generators. "What we need is warm silence," wrote Simone Weil, "what we get is icy tumult." The cold stream of manipulation erodes us into caricatures of ourselves.

Confirmation bias, the third brain hack, works together with the fourth, social conformity. In real life, we tend to accept what people around us say; on the internet, the algorithms nestle us in an environment where we seem to be with like-minded people. Of course, some of the apparent people are bots, and others are pseudonymous fakes. (In the 2020 presidential election, the biggest Facebook group for American Christians was run by non-American non-Christians.) Even were there no non-people and no fake people, a silo is not a consensus—let alone the truth about the world. Our social media nemesis just groups clickers into conformist cocoons.

For us, the experience of having our brains hacked is emotional and political, even as our emotions hollow and our politics narrow. Our opinions, showered upon us, must be correct. Our feelings, repeatedly reinforced, become obsessive. We grow unshakably certain on matters about which we have zero knowledge. We come to believe that people who think differently are malicious. If we hear other people speak their minds, we are instantly suspicious. We are presented with images of the enemy on the internet, but rarely have contact with the bodies of other people in real life.

Our prejudices, confirmed when our social media nemesis doses us with fear, begin to harden. We control them until we feel attacked: social media regularly provide a splash of offense and violation, even when nothing has actually happened. We are sure that we are the victims: right now, in the future, in the past, always. My tribe never did anything wrong. They are the real racists. It was not my side that suppressed the vote. It must have been the other side that stole the election.

Our fears are cultivated to conform to what others in our categories fear. If you are a middle-aged white male and you fear exactly what other middle-aged white males fear, you have been had. When your fears are predictable, then so are you, which means that you (and your digital demographic) are ripe for manipulation. When you are predictable, you predictably bring your country down.

Led LeaderlessConforming, you are easily led. Having withdrawn from the rugged borderland of the unpredictable into the cozy cove of your digital demographic, you await orders, or nudges. You have exposed your buttons, and you wait for them to be stroked and pushed. Anyone (or anything) that caresses your naked anxieties will also be arousing those of the legion of cowards in which you have enlisted. The more people there are who fear the same things, the easier tyranny becomes. Unfreedom is efficient.

Our social media nemesis is thinking without being a thinker. It is conspiracy theorizing without there being a conspiracy theorist. To be sure, there is a human intelligence (at least so far) inventing the lies that the machine amplifies: Russians in St. Petersburg, for example, who claim that Hillary Clinton kidnaps children. But the amplification is digital.

As wealth is distributed ever more unevenly, the fantasies and whimsies of oligarchs get pride of place on our screens. Putin says Ukraine does not exist, and Elon Musk boosts the lie; hydrocarbon companies claim that global warming is not a problem, and Elon Musk boosts the lie; Trump says that he won the election of 2020, and Elon Musk boosts the lie. These lies then grow within us thanks to mental vulnerabilities that machines find and exploit.

When our brains are hacked, we can be led without a leader. As we expose our vulnerabilities, we become more vulnerable. As we come to feel more lonely and helpless, we are more likely to believe in ideologies that explain everything, conspiracy theories that make sense of the world, big lies that reassure us of our place in it.

The data about us, generated for advertisers, is sold to politicians or to oligarchs wishing to support them. Candidates can win elections by having superior knowledge of citizens' beliefs and fears, or by having others deploy the data for them. Politicians test phrases online before uttering them in real life. Talk radio hosts gain popularity by following what gets attention on social media during the day and then repeating it in the evening.

A politician who wins office with the help of algorithms is unlikely to lead us into a human future. Such a person is a character in a digital story, not its author, a mouthpiece of a politics of "us and them," contributing dwindling creativity to brain hacks. It is less shocking now than it was just a few years ago when a presidential candidate calls people "vermin," promises to imprison political opponents, plans to disassemble the government, and glorifies concentration camps. For the algorithms to get our attention, they need ever more drastic material.

Americans do disagree about many things, but why do so many of us seem ready for violence? Why did people storm the Capitol in January 2021 on the basis of falsehoods from screens? The lies invented by a few individuals were directed, by practiced algorithms, toward mass vulnerabilities. Why are we, so predictably, setting ourselves up for another scenario in which a presidential candidate loses the vote and then claims the office? We are being led leaderless into a calamity.

Self-Built CagesA sovereign person declares and accommodates. Values are declared and accommodated with one another. Others are recognized as they do the same thing. We become unpredictable—free—together.

Declaring and accommodating are the basic capacities of a sovereign person. Exercised alongside other sovereign people, declarations and accommodations generate an unforeseen realm, a land of the free. Coming to know other people, we know the world and ourselves better. Our values, our sense of what is right and what is wrong, are tested along with this everyday knowledge. This is what is best about us and what enables us to be free.

Our capacity for freedom, though, has a tragic flaw. Those capacities for declaration and accommodation, which are meant to greet and judge values and people, can also be drawn in another direction. Our nemesis captures these capacities and turns them against us, shifting us away from one another and toward our most probable states. Online, we declare ourselves, and social media extract data. We accommodate algorithms, and social media extract more. Our digital nemesis takes hold of our capacities, draws us into its fold, and beats us down for good and all. It acts, and we react, and we come to treat this as normal. It subdues our will without having a will of its own. We are predictified.

At first, the machine demobilizes. It takes up the time we need to attend to the bodies of others. It consumes energy and imagination. It tends to provide us with reasons not to act: not to exercise, not to make love, not to make friends, not to help our neighbor, not to vote, not to demonstrate. But at some point, when the algorithms locate our political fantasies, we find ourselves acting on the basis of unreality.

This fantasy, predictably, will have to do with a threat from others. A fearful world of "us and them" suppresses our capacities to see diversity and express empathy. Our fear is there to meet physical threats, planting us firmly (and predictably) in the first three dimensions. There is no time for evaluation, no fourth or fifth dimension. We feel that we must act immediately and that the choice is binary. Can we flee, or should we fight? We feel that we must act right now.

The fantasy arises from untruth. A lie belongs to someone else, and believing it puts you in someone else's thrall. You are predictable to the person who writes your lines. As the Indian novelist Arundhati Roy put it, the danger is not that the chatbots replace us but that we become the chatbots. The Russian thinker Mikhail Bakhtin said that "he who is deceived is turned into a thing." In the digital age, this can mean becoming objects that serve other objects. We cannot expect our nemesis, the pied piper of objects, to feel remorse about this.

Our nemesis moves us via fiction to do something in the real world, such as voting for a candidate who plays on our fears over Twitter, or invading the sanctuary of democracy for a big lie we read on Facebook. Then a line has been crossed. Having been recruited by algorithms for action in the real world, we rationalize, using our dwindling ingenuity to give our recruiter an alibi. Our minds become inferior search engines, set to find excuses for superior ones.

This is cognitive dissonance, the fifth and final brain hack, the machine's coup de grâce. We use what is left of our

human reason to defend actions that were based on an alien one. We retreat from the borderland of the unpredictable and surrender the realm of freedom: not just for ourselves but for others who must endure our preprogrammed rants, senseless violence, and tiresome rationalizations.

The philosopher Lev Shestov wrote of “living automata, which some mysterious hand has wound up.” Our nemesis winds us up, like toys. We are physically immobile while our emotions tense, then uncoil into action for reasons that are not our own. We become unfree in the simplest of matters, not doing what we would if we were thinking for ourselves.

Freedom needs human thinkers, sovereign and unpredictable. Unfreedom needs yielding and predictable creatures, quaking from fear in self-built cages, dreaming of enemies they never meet, and of friends and lovers they do not have.

When we see how the brain hacks work, we can escape predictification. That will involve changing the internet, but it will also require doing other things with our bodies than staring at screens. It is our move.

Radical TraditionMy friend Adam Michnik, the onetime Polish dissident, was a visitor at Yale in spring 2016. When I asked how he was doing, he responded that his fellowship at the law school was “almost as good as prison.”

The joke had a point: it was the first time since his own release from prison that he had had the time to sit and read books. His best work had arisen during a long period of incarceration. Reflecting later on what he said, I realized that, in a much smaller way, I owed some concentration to prison as well.

In my prison class in 2022, the students did the assigned reading carefully, and I did the same. I was not allowed to have any electronics in the prison classroom, and of course neither were they. It was just us and the authors, without any distraction. When there was a break between the morning and the afternoon sessions, I would sit with this manuscript and edit it by hand.

By the standard of people on the outside, my students were quite radical. By the standards of what they would themselves have chosen to read, their syllabus was quite conservative. The point of teaching philosophy in prison is not that the thinkers are correct about everything, or that the students were always correct in their criticisms. Traditions are an enriching restraint. In order to build on traditions, to correct them, we have to know them, and that takes time. Our current mood of discarding the past, usually on some self-righteous ground, has to do with our engineered inability to concentrate and tolerate. We are trained by our social media nemesis to join the herd and cull the herd. If we refuse to read, though, we are not trading the past for the future. Without the past, there can be no future. We are trading the past for quibbly static.

Past thinkers have warnings for us, including a warning precisely about that. We live amid devices that make us predictable, that predictify us. For thousands of years of literature, from ancient Greek poems through contemporary science fiction, writers have been concerned that we might create such machines. As this is now happening, we are forgetting the traditions meant to protect us.

George Orwell saw vocabulary as enabling what we are calling sovereignty and unpredictability. The plurality of virtues is real, but in his novel 1984, people lack the words to name them. People are unfree not simply because their bodies are always observed but because their language is famished. In 1984, the reduction of the number of English words is a cumbersome affair, drudge work carried out by people in offices. In our lives, social media reduce our vocabulary (and thus our references) at terrifying speed. Colonized on our couches, we accept a pidgin of English.

In Ray Bradbury’s novel Fahrenheit 451, firefighters burn books while everyone is expected to spend leisure time in front of a screen. Its protagonist, a fireman, is able to gain distance from what he is doing as he reads books and regains words. The story closes with his escape to a wandering group of people who preserve literature by learning whole books by heart. The small band of people doing this are articulate, humble, and spontaneous. They have decided to stick together. This is how the greatest of books arose and endured.

One such was the Iliad, the story of a Greek attack on the city of Troy, preserved for hundreds of years by groups of poets and performers before it was set down in writing. For this chapter, a word I needed was nemesis: our own self-involved actions now create for us an enemy that can overcome us later, in a way that we darkly deserve, and that

we can overcome only by knowing ourselves. That notion of nemesis comes (for me at least) from the Iliad, and from the Greek dramas set after the destruction of Troy. The long poem was codified in about 500 b.c. Its Greek manuscript was then preserved by hand copying for about two thousand years. A few copies reached Italy from Constantinople a few years before Byzantium fell in 1453. After the Iliad was finally published, heroes such as Achilles, Hector, and Odysseus populated tapestries, paintings, and poems.

In the Odyssey, a story that follows the Iliad, crafty Odysseus faces a series of trials as he seeks to return home after the victory at Troy. One of these was the Island of Lotus Eaters, where endless pleasant stimulation extinguishes personality. Odysseus was held on another island by Calypso, who gave him everything except the freedom to go where he wished. The most apposite test was that of the sirens. Their song was irresistible because they adapted it to each listener—like the algorithms of today. Anyone who yielded to their summons would die, as the skeletons on the shore of their island attested. We are drawn by what seems to be about us, even to entities that we know we cannot trust.

Odysseus wanted to understand the sirens, but he also wanted to live and move on. He knew how vulnerable his body was, but also what it could do. He made a plan with his men. He had his sailors stop their ears with wax and tie his body to the mast. He heard the sirens, he felt his limits, he learned, and he persisted.

That is where we are. Like Odysseus and his ship, we have the technology we need to live and move. We have also created a digital siren song that will tell each of us what we want to hear, until we are no more, forgotten skeletons on a nameless shore. Together, though, we can understand our nemesis and ourselves, and move on.

It took him twenty years, the time we need to become sovereign and unpredictable. But Odysseus made it home.

MobilityWolf's WordAs a little kid, I was lucky to have a babysitter, Donna, who told me Greek myths as bedtime stories. Later I checked out books of mythology from the public library. I read Edith Hamilton's summaries under my desk in elementary school. The Iliad and the Odyssey followed, first in summaries or illustrated abridgments from the public library, then in full form. I read a few of the Greek dramas that began where the Iliad ended, such as Iphigenia in Tauris by Euripides. My father thought I should get out more.

And I was fortunate to grow up in a family that took me on journeys, whether I wanted to go or not. My parents knew Spanish and were comfortable in Latin America. As a fourteen-year-old on a trip to Costa Rica, I felt free, thanks to them. In the cloud forest of Monteverde, in May 1984, my brothers and I hiked every day, guided by a local kid, Ian. We walked or ran the paths from morning to evening, water and food and knives in backpacks, feeling self-sufficient and happy. We saw sloths and monkeys and the elusive quetzal.

One day Ian promised us something special, a mysterious quest. We walked on and on, but he remained taciturn. After three hours or so on a dirt road, we wandered through a maze of cloud forest paths, some visible, some of which seemed only to exist in Ian's imagination, some where I wished I had brought a machete. Then we heard the rush, everything opened up, and we saw the waterfall. It had a clear pool, both in front and behind, where there was a cave. We could swim into the cave and look out at the green world through tons of falling water.

That evening, too tired to speak myself, I sat at the edge of a conversation of older men. I heard a term that fascinated me after a day on the paths. The people my family knew in Monteverde were Quaker Cold War refugees who had managed to establish a dairy commune on a plateau. The English they spoke was right out of the Midwest, in some cases right out of my parents' home county in Ohio. The topic was the protection of habitat.

Two of the older gentlemen (Roy Joe and Wolf) got to talking about a path in the cloud forest, about whether it was available for public use. The term they used was right of way: Was this path a "right of way"? Did anyone have the right to use it? They pronounced the phrase like "right away," which only added to its appeal.

That's what I wanted, at fourteen. I wanted a right of way, right away. I wanted to know that there would be a path. As I didn't quite then understand, someone else would have blazed it. I took what I could get. A public high school was awaiting me in Ohio, with a few teachers who could deal with me, and a debate team with a patient coach. The country highways, empty at night, invited me to speedy calm, as they had my father. And when the time came, I claimed my right of way, my right to get away, my little American Dream.

I visited Costa Rica twice more, once in my early twenties and once in my late forties. During those later visits, I continued to appreciate the beauty and gave some thought to the politics. Here is a country that designates more than a quarter of its territory as park or refuge, that generates its electricity from renewable sources, that provides health care to its citizens. Costa Ricans live longer than Americans. Their political system scores much higher on freedom than the American one (on the American measures kept by the American organization Freedom House).

Costa Ricans do far better than Americans on all the happiness scales. And though it is impossible to quantify, people there do seem to feel more free.

Life's ArcWhen I was hiking in Costa Rica as a kid, it was the paths through the cloud forests that liberated me. They existed, of course, only because of the work of other people, and they opened to me thanks to a guide and encouraging adults. If a trail is blazed, then someone else blazed it; if you blaze a trail, it's for someone else. It's still true that moving my body helps me to be free, to the point of enabling me to write. That I can do so, though, is the result of the labor of others.

We all need a right of way. Mobility is the third form of freedom: capable movement in space and time and among values, an arc of life whose trajectory we choose and alter as we go. For all of us, mobility means access to food, water, hygiene, health care, parks and paths, roads and railways, to help us make what we can of our bodies. Access includes safety: we are not free to go where it is not safe to go, especially when we are responsible for children.

For some of us, mobility means the time and encouragement to take care of our bodies. For others, it means more substantial support for our ability to move. None of us is capable of mobility without assistance. Those who require more assistance remind us of our general condition. We all need some help; beyond this general realization, it is all a matter of degree.

Although the individual Leib is mobile, mobility for all can be achieved only together. Mobility for individuals requires collective political attention to the logic of life: the risk of injury and illness, the progression from infancy to old age. Mobility is a form of freedom because we are free when we structure society with this in mind. It is not so much a final state as an accumulation of capacities and imaginings over the course of a life.

One of my relatives is blind and has limited movement. The better the technology around her, the better she can express herself. My friend stricken with ALS was more free, I like to think, when we were together doing something. Physical presence could generate a sense of spiritual freedom. But as I learned to operate his gear, another simple truth struck home: he was freer when he had a functional wheelchair (and would have been freer still had it been provided by American health care). Soldiers in Ukraine who have lost limbs to artillery are aided by prostheses and time and care. Rehabilitation belongs to freedom, and so does attention to aging. As the average population age, geroscience—preventive treatment of the afflictions associated with old age—becomes important to our liberty.

Care is important, as is the prior confidence that it will be there. We are more mobile when we can count on certain basic human requirements being met. If we knew that we had access to health care and a retirement pension, we would live more interesting lives. Lacking such confidence, we will be stuck where we are. Most Americans report receiving medical bills they cannot pay, which means being stuck in illness. For middle-class people, dependence on private health care makes it difficult to change jobs. This drastic restraint on mobility—and thus on freedom—is, sadly, taken for granted in the United States.

Poverty forces people into their most probable states. It impedes mobility. This is a point my students in prison made repeatedly. My student Marquis called poverty "the daily basis of unfreedom" and said that for many people he knows, freedom would begin with three meals a day and a decent school.

The first three forms of freedom—sovereignty, unpredictability, and mobility—should be present throughout our lives. There is nevertheless an order of development. In childhood, we attain sovereignty, with the help of others; in youth, we sustain unpredictability as we realize our own combinations of values. As we become adults, we need somewhere to go and the ability to get there.

Mobility is the challenge of maturity. To break free means to move in all five dimensions. It means having a waterfall to find or a mountain to climb, a day to do it, another to reflect on it. In the romantic imagery of freedom,

we get to that idyll ourselves. In reality, all of us have help.

I love the places I am from, but I am glad that I could leave when I did. We all need mobility, but young adults need it in a special way. If everything goes as it should, they become sovereign and unpredictable, then break free of the structures (and the people) that allowed them to become so. But when those structures of mobility are not present, or when the structures are designed to immobilize and humiliate, rebellion takes on a different sense.

Can You Imagine?Irene Morgan came of age in America during the Second World War. In 1944 she was a working mother. She commuted from Maryland to work for a defense contractor in Virginia that was building American bombers. In Maryland, she could sit where she liked on the bus, but in Virginia, she was required by law to move to the back. One day, particularly tired after a doctor's appointment, she was asked to yield her place in the back of the crowded bus to a white couple. She was then removed by force from the bus and beaten. But her case went all the way to the Supreme Court, and she won. In 1946 segregation in interstate travel became illegal, in theory. Nothing much changed in practice.

It was humiliating for African Americans to be segregated while traveling. Rather than simply moving from place to place, for purposes of their own, they were singled out. What should have been unreflective motion became a series of encounters (and the anxious anticipation thereof) that were meant to be reminders of inferiority. Black people had to sit at the back of the bus or in a certain part of a certain wagon of a train. At each station, they had to use a different restroom and order food at a different counter.

Irene Morgan was helping to build airplanes. During the Second World War, a few African American men were trained to fly them. As one future pilot crossed the Mason-Dixon Line on his way to Alabama for training, he had to leave one train car and board another, just behind the locomotive. He and the other Black men on the train noticed that their places were then taken by German prisoners of war. The enemy was given more consideration than they. This sort of thing was recalled by a number of African American veterans.

Leon Bass, who volunteered to serve in the army, was humiliated as he trained for service on military bases in the South. He recalled a restaurant beyond the base where German prisoners could eat but he could not.

Bass fought on the western front of the European Theater, including in the Battle of the Bulge. He ended up in a group of American soldiers who reached the German concentration camp at Buchenwald. (As a nurse pointed out at the time, liberation was not the word for it, since former inmates kept dying and the survivors needed much more than the departure of their guards to be regarded as free.) Recalling Buchenwald, Bass said, "Racism is at the root of all of this. Under that umbrella comes bigotry and prejudice and discrimination. We haven't come to grips with that institution called racism. And we have to, because we see the ultimate of racism, which was what I saw at Buchenwald."

More than a million African Americans served in the segregated American armed forces during the Second World War. Black veterans returning home found an unchanged Jim Crow regime, regulating where their bodies could be. Leon Bass was refused service at a restaurant. "Can you imagine?" he said. "I put in three years of my life, put it on the line to make it possible for people like that young lady and that manager or whoever owned that store to function and enjoy the rights and privileges of Americans, and they were saying to me, just like the Nazis did, just like they told me down in the South, what they told my father, 'Leon, you're not good enough.' What a damnable kind of thing to say to somebody."

Some returning Black veterans challenged customary immobility. Wilson Hood sat where he liked on a bus from Atlanta to Washington, D.C., though on the way he was threatened with murder in Chapel Hill, North Carolina. As Isaac Woodard tried to return from a military base in Georgia to his home in North Carolina, he was severely beaten and permanently blinded. Both of his eyes were gouged out by a white man using a billy club.

Freedom RidesIn 1960 the Supreme Court ruled that racial segregation in bus terminals was unconstitutional. In May 1961 a group of "Freedom Riders" tested the new norm on the stops between Washington, D.C., and New Orleans. This first Freedom Ride was organized by the Congress of Racial Equality. One of its founders, Jim Peck, had watched the rise of Nazi Germany from Paris. Another Freedom Rider, John Lewis, wrote in his application to join the group of bringing "freedom to the Deep South." The Freedom Riders sat on buses and used facilities heedless of local custom and state law. In South Carolina, Lewis and two other Riders were attacked. In Alabama,

one bus was bombed and set aflame, and the passengers were beaten when they escaped.